

SOME STORIES END
WITHOUT EVER BEGINNING.

the space between *waiting*

— ❁ —
A COLLEGE LOVE STORY
OF FRIENDSHIP,
UNSPOKEN WORDS,
AND THE HEART
THAT CHOSE
TO STAY.

— ❁ —
BY

Y A S H

— ❁ —

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before You Begin

This is a story about love — but not the kind that gets rewarded at the end.

There is a boy who loves deeply. There is a girl who cares deeply. Neither of them is wrong. Neither of them is a villain. And yet, something breaks. Something always does, when we confuse kindness for a promise, when we mistake someone's presence for permission to expect their heart.

I want you to know something before you read this: caring for someone is not a transaction. Being there for a person, remembering their birthday, knowing how they take their coffee, showing up every time they call — none of it creates a debt. Love is not owed. Love cannot be earned through patience and sacrifice alone. And asking someone to love you the way you love them is not love anymore. It becomes something heavier than that.

Dhruv's story broke my heart as I wrote it. Not because he is weak. But because he is so painfully human. He hopes. He waits. He gives everything and holds on long after the holding becomes harmful — to himself, and quietly, to her.

Ananya never lied to him. She never promised anything she didn't mean. She cared for him genuinely. That is what makes this so tragic — there is no one to blame.

Sometimes, two people can be perfectly kind to each other and still tear each other apart just by feeling different things.

If you have ever waited for someone who didn't come — this book is for you. If you have ever been the person someone was waiting for, and you didn't know what to do with that — this book is also for you.

The bravest thing Dhruv ever does happens quietly, near the end. I hope you recognize it when you see it.

Sometimes, letting go is the deepest form of love.

— *Yash*

PART ONE

The Beginning

The First Day

The bus to Meghna College arrived six minutes late, and Dhruv Malhotra almost missed it.

He had been standing at the wrong stop — the one in front of the stationary shop on Station Road, not the one at the corner where the neem tree grew sideways over the footpath. He only realized his mistake when he noticed a group of students with canvas bags and brand-new identity card lanyards walking past him in the opposite direction. He picked up his backpack, jogged to the corner, and reached the bus just as the conductor was about to wave it forward.

He found a window seat near the middle and spent the twenty-minute ride looking out at the city. It was mid-July, the sky swollen with grey clouds, the kind that promised rain but hadn't delivered yet. The roads were wet from last night. Auto rickshaws honked. A woman on a scooter balanced a tiffin box between her knees. An old man fed crows from a newspaper cone on the footpath.

Dhruv watched all of it. He had a habit of doing that — watching things carefully, storing them, like he might need them later for something he hadn't figured out yet.

He was nervous. He knew he was nervous because his left knee was bouncing slightly, and he'd read his college ID card three times already without needing to.

DHRUV MALHOTRA. ROLL NO: 2401. B.COM (HONS). YEAR 1.

The college campus was larger than he'd expected. Two main buildings connected by a covered walkway. A small garden with a fountain that was clearly broken — the water came out sideways and nobody had fixed it. A notice board with at least forty overlapping sheets of paper pinned to it. A canteen visible through an archway, already crowded, the smell of samosas drifting out even at 8:45 in the morning.

He followed the signs to the orientation hall. B.Com batch. Ground floor. Room 104.

He was early, so there were only a handful of students inside. He chose a seat in the fourth row — not too front, not too far back. He placed his bag on the floor, took out a notebook he hadn't written in yet, and uncapped a pen.

The room filled slowly. Students came in pairs and small groups, already talking. Most of them seemed to already know someone. Dhruv watched them. He wondered if everyone except him had some kind of orientation-day manual that told them how to walk into a room full of strangers and act like they belonged.

He didn't have that.

He wrote the date at the top of the first page of his notebook. 18 July. Then he wasn't sure what else to write, so he drew a small box in the corner and then drew another smaller box inside it.

That was when the chair next to him scraped back.

He looked up.

A girl sat down. She had a yellow dupatta — the only yellow thing in the room — and she was slightly out of breath, like she had been running. She dropped her bag on the floor with more force than she'd intended, and it knocked against his foot.

"Sorry," she said immediately. She looked at him, and she had this expression — not embarrassed exactly, more like someone trying not to laugh at themselves. "That bag has been attacking people all morning."

Dhruv looked at the bag. It was a large olive-green canvas tote, slightly too full, with one strap longer than the other. "It's fine," he said.

She nodded, then turned to look at the front of the room where a professor was arranging papers on the desk. Then she turned back. "I went to the wrong building," she said, like she was continuing a conversation they'd already been having. "I followed the map on the website, and the map was wrong. There are two Rooms 104 apparently."

"Ah," he said.

"I went to the science block first. Very confusing orientation for about three minutes." She smiled, and it was the kind of smile that changed the shape of her whole face — her eyes narrowed, a small dimple appeared on her left cheek. "I'm Ananya."

"Dhruv."

"Do you know anyone here?"

"No."

"Good. Me neither. That's reassuring." She opened her own notebook. It already had some things written in it. A to-do list, a doodle of a flower, some phone numbers. She looked back up at him. "Are you nervous?"

He paused. "Yeah."

"Me too," she said, as if that settled something.

Then the professor called the room to attention, and they both turned to face the front.

Later, Dhruv wouldn't be able to tell you what the professor said during those first forty-five minutes. He could tell you that Ananya wrote with a blue pen, that she underlined things in two strokes, that she had a small moon charm on her bag zipper, that she laughed once under her breath at something the professor said about academic integrity, and that her handwriting was surprisingly neat for someone who seemed so scattered.

He paid attention to all of that, without really meaning to.

It was just the way he was.

"The most dangerous conversations are the ones that feel like nothing at all."

— CHAPTER ONE

Orientation

Orientation lasted three days. On the first day, they sat through five sessions and ate lunch from stalls that had been set up outside the canteen. Dhruv got a plate of chole bhature and stood at the edge of the crowd eating, watching everyone sort themselves into groups the way iron filings sort themselves around magnets. The confident ones found each other. The quiet ones drifted to the walls. The ones who had friends from school stuck to them like they were the only solid thing in the room.

Ananya found him. He didn't expect it.

He was standing under a tree near the parking lot, balancing his plate and trying not to drop his plastic cup of nimbu pani, when she appeared at his elbow with her own plate of chole bhature and said, "You got the same thing. Good. I heard the aloo tikki was disappointing."

He blinked. "Okay."

"Is there space here? You look like you've claimed this tree."

"I haven't," he said. "You can stand here."

She stood beside him. They ate in silence for a while. It wasn't the uncomfortable kind of silence, which surprised him. He was used to silences

being things he had to fill, or explain, or apologize for. This one just sat between them, easy as a chair.

"What did you think of the third session?" she asked.

"The one about the internal exam pattern?"

"Yes. The professor made it sound terrifying."

"I think it was just information," he said. "It sounded worse because she spoke very fast."

Ananya considered this. "That's true. She spoke like she was reading from a train announcement." She ate a bite. "Where are you from originally?"

"Here. Born here. My whole family's here."

"I'm from Nagpur," she said. "I moved here three weeks ago. My aunt's place, in Kothrud."

"Do you like it?"

"I like that it rains here. Nagpur is too hot. But I haven't made friends yet." She said this the same way she'd said everything else — matter-of-factly, without self-pity. Just information.

Dhruv nodded. He didn't say anything. He wasn't sure what to say. He was aware that most people, hearing someone say they hadn't made friends yet, would respond with something reassuring. He didn't know if that was what she wanted, or if she was just noting a fact.

She ate another bite. Then she said, "Do you have friends from school here?"

"One. Rohan. He got into engineering, so he's at a different college."

"So we're both starting from scratch."

"Yeah."

"That's fine," she said. And she sounded like she meant it.

On the second day of orientation, they ended up at the same table in the hall. Not by design — the hall was crowded and they arrived at the same time and the only two adjacent empty seats were in the middle of a row that required climbing over several bags. They sat together by default, and then by choice.

Dhruv learned things.

She was the eldest of two sisters. She wanted to do an MBA eventually. She had studied in a Marathi-medium school and had worked very hard to get comfortable in English, which explained why she spoke it with a precision that sometimes sounded formal — she chose her words carefully, the way you do when you've learned them late. She was allergic to something that made her eyes water sometimes, but she wasn't sure what it was. She liked old Bollywood songs, especially the ones from the 1970s. She hated the smell of hospitals. She had once cried at a documentary about glaciers.

He didn't ask her all of this at once. It came out in pieces, between sessions, in the margin of the day. She talked the way some people think — freely, without an obvious beginning or end, following the track of whatever was in front of her.

He mostly listened. He found he was good at that, and that she liked being listened to.

On the third day — the last day of orientation — they had a campus tour led by two second-year students who spoke with the slightly bored authority of people who had done this before. The tour went through the library, the computer lab, the gym, the auditorium, the NSS room, and finally the rooftop terrace, which had a view of the city that made everyone quiet for a moment.

Ananya stood at the railing. The sky was enormous from up here, blue-grey, and the city spread out below in tiles of terracotta and grey concrete, autorickshaws moving through it like orange beetles.

"I think I'm going to like it here," she said.

It wasn't a question. Dhruv didn't respond. He just stood next to her and looked at the same view, and felt something settle in his chest — some small, quiet thing, like a bird landing on a branch.

He didn't name it then. He wouldn't name it for a long time.

But it was there.

She talked the way some people think — freely, without an obvious beginning or end, following the track of whatever was in front of her.

At the end of orientation, they exchanged numbers. It was a practical thing — she asked if she could send him the notes from the first session, which she had taken more carefully than him. He said yes and gave her his

number. She saved it as "Dhruv B.Com" and showed him so he would know how he was labeled in her phone.

He saved hers as "Ananya."

Just that. No last name. No label.

Just her name, sitting there at the top of his contacts, already different from everyone else.

"She saved his number with a label. He saved hers with just her name. That was already the whole story, if you knew how to read it."

— CHAPTER TWO

Canteen Table Seven

Classes started the following Monday.

The B.Com (Hons) batch had sixty-two students, two sections, and four core subjects in the first semester: Financial Accounting, Business Economics, Business Mathematics, and Communication Skills. Dhruv's section was Section A. Ananya was also in Section A.

He noticed this when the professor read out the roll numbers on the first day, and he wasn't sure whether to be glad or embarrassed by how glad he was.

In the beginning, they sat next to each other out of habit — they had already established a proximity during orientation, and it felt natural to continue it. There was a comfort in having a known person nearby in a room full of strangers. He understood that this was what it was. He didn't think it was anything more than that.

The canteen became their place by accident.

It happened like this: on the third day of classes, Dhruv arrived at the canteen during the lunch break to find every table full. He stood at the entrance with his plate of rice and dal, scanning the room, when Ananya appeared from behind him and said, "There's a table in the back. That one in the corner. But it only has two seats."

"That's fine," he said.

Table seven was the last table on the left side, pressed against the wall near the window that looked out onto the college garden. It was slightly apart from the others, which meant it was always the last one to fill up and the first one to empty. The two plastic chairs were slightly mismatched — one was green, one was orange. A ceiling fan above it spun at a speed that was either very slow or slightly broken.

They ate. They talked about Business Mathematics, which had turned out to be harder than either of them expected. She was better at economics. He was better at accounting. She told him she had made friends with a girl named Priya from her hostel building, who was in Section B. He nodded. He had not made friends with anyone new yet. He was not quick at that.

"You're very quiet," she said at one point. Not as a criticism. Just as an observation.

"I know," he said.

"I don't mean that in a bad way. I just mean — most people your age talk a lot. You don't."

"Talking a lot doesn't always mean you have more to say."

She looked at him for a moment. "That's actually a good point." She ate a spoonful of dal. "I talk too much. My mother always said I fill silences just to hear myself."

"I think you fill silences because you're interested in things," Dhruv said. "That's different."

She looked at him again, this time with a slightly different expression. Surprised, maybe. Then she smiled — that same full-face smile from the

first day. "Okay, I like you," she said, simply. "You're going to be my canteen friend."

He didn't say anything to that. But he felt something happen in the region of his chest that he would spend the next three years trying to correctly identify.

Table seven became their table. Not by agreement or announcement — it just happened the way most important things happen, gradually and without ceremony. If Dhruv arrived first, he chose table seven and waited. If she arrived first, she chose table seven and saved the orange chair for him, because he had mentioned once that the green chair's leg was slightly uneven.

She had remembered that.

He noticed that she remembered it.

He didn't say anything about it. He just sat in the orange chair and ate his lunch and talked about whatever she was talking about, and underneath all of that, very quietly, the small bird in his chest settled deeper into the branch, and he felt the first faint suggestion of something he would not name for months.

The canteen had its own rhythms. The samosa rush at 10:30. The dosa peak between 1:00 and 1:30. The tea break at 3:15, when the professors disappeared for exactly twenty minutes. The evening chai that was weaker than it should have been but was hot enough to hold in both hands.

He learned all of these by going there with her.

He learned that she liked the veg fried rice over the plain rice. That she always ordered a small cup of curd on the side regardless of what she was eating. That she didn't like the canteen's samosas because they were too salty, but she sometimes ate one anyway and made the same face every time, a resigned grimace that he found unreasonably endearing. That she drank her chai with one sugar, not two, because "two sugars is for people who need a mood lift and I'm already in a good mood."

He stored all of it carefully, the way he stored everything: without knowing why, except that it seemed important.

In those early weeks, Dhruv made two other friends. Sameer, from his neighbourhood, who had also ended up in Meghna College and sat in the last row of every class. And Kavya, a girl from Goa who had a very loud laugh and was in Section A and had somehow already memorized the name of every professor in the department by the second week.

Ananya's friend circle grew faster than his. She had Priya, and a girl named Riyawho lived near her aunt's place, and a few others from Section B who started eating lunch with her on days when Dhruv had a lab or an extra session. But she always came back to table seven when it was just the two of them. Or she'd send him a message that said: *Canteen after 1? Saving the orange chair.*

He would read that message on his phone and look at it slightly longer than a message like that warranted.

Then he would type: *Coming.*

And he would walk a little faster down the corridor toward the canteen, and he would tell himself it was only because he was hungry.

"She saved him the orange chair. He told himself it was just friendliness. He would spend a long time believing that."

— CHAPTER THREE

The Library Corner

The college library was on the second floor of the main building, and it had a personality problem.

The left side — the side with the reference books and the periodicals — was serious and hushed, the kind of quiet that felt enforced rather than natural. The fluorescent lights were slightly too bright, and the shelves were tall enough that you had to stand on the lower rung of the shelf to reach the top row. The right side had a row of windows overlooking the garden, wooden study tables, and an unofficial understanding that it was okay to whisper there, as long as you kept it brief.

Dhruv preferred the right side. He discovered this about himself in the third week of college, when he spent an afternoon there studying for a surprise quiz in Business Economics. He liked the light from the windows, which changed through the afternoon as the sun moved. He liked being able to see the garden. He liked that people there were quiet, but not pretending to be.

He ran into Ananya there on a Thursday in August.

She was sitting at the second window table, her notes spread out in a system that looked chaotic but clearly made sense to her. She had her headphones around her neck — not in her ears — and a half-empty bottle of water. She was frowning at something in her textbook with the focused intensity of someone trying to decode a message.

He stood in the doorway for a moment, not sure whether to interrupt. Then she looked up, saw him, and waved once — a small, efficient wave, like a flag being raised and immediately lowered.

He walked over. "Studying?"

She looked around the library, then back at him. "...Yes."

"Right." He felt foolish. "I meant — Business Economics?"

"The demand curves are killing me." She held up her textbook. "Who decided that the best way to explain consumer behavior was with this many graphs?"

"Someone who loved graphs."

"Clearly. Are you here to study? Sit."

He sat across from her. He took out his own notes. For the next two hours, they studied at the same table — not together exactly, but alongside each other. She asked him to explain two concepts, and he did, drawing the curves on a spare piece of paper while she watched. He asked her to check his cost-benefit analysis, and she found two errors and fixed them without making him feel bad about it.

They took a break at four o'clock and went down to the canteen for tea. She drank hers — one sugar — while reading from her notes. He drank his and looked out the window at the garden, where a cat had appeared on the boundary wall and was sitting with the serene indifference of an entity that didn't need to pass any exams.

"I'm not good at this kind of studying," she said suddenly.

"What kind?"

"The kind where you sit for two hours and nothing goes in." She put down her notes. "I read something and I understand it but then if you ask me an hour later, it's gone. Like water through a sieve."

"You could try teaching it to someone," he said. "That helps it stick. You teach it out loud and it goes in deeper."

"Teach it to who?"

He shrugged. "Me."

She considered this. "Right now?"

"We have forty minutes before the library closes."

So they went back upstairs, and she explained demand elasticity to him, standing in front of her notes like a professor in front of a whiteboard, occasionally tapping the page. He listened and asked real questions — not to help her practice, but because he was genuinely trying to understand. And she answered them, and as she answered them, he watched her face change. She went from uncertain to confident in real time, her explanations growing clearer, her voice dropping into that lower, more settled register that people find when they actually know what they're saying.

"Okay," she said when she finished. "I think I actually understand it now."

"You understood it before. You just needed to hear yourself say it."

She tilted her head at him. That same slightly surprised look. "You're good at knowing what people need," she said. It was a simple observation. She

wasn't being flattering. She was just noticing.

He didn't know what to say, so he said, "I just pay attention."

"Most people don't," she said.

Then she started packing her notes into her bag, and the conversation moved on to something else — whether the Business Maths professor would give a unit test before Diwali, and whether the hostel mess food was actually as bad as everyone said. He answered her and asked his own questions, and by the time they were both heading out of the library, he had already shelved what she'd said. He had stored it somewhere quiet and moved on.

But it stayed there, that small sentence, deep in some drawer he didn't often open.

You're good at knowing what people need.

He came back to the library on Friday. And the following Thursday. And the Thursday after that. Eventually he had a fixed routine: Thursday afternoons, second window table, right side. And Ananya had her own separate routine, but it overlapped enough that she was there most Thursdays, and when she was, they studied, and they took a break for tea, and they walked back down the stairs together.

Nobody decided this was their thing. It became their thing the way all important things did: without announcement, simply by being repeated until it was expected.

"They never agreed to meet. They just kept finding each other in the same place. That's how it starts, always — not with a plan, but with a habit."

— CHAPTER FOUR

Her Name in His Notes

Dhruv kept a notebook for each subject. He was organized in this way even though he wasn't organized in most others. His room at home was cluttered — books and clothes and old bills stacked in ways that suggested good intentions that had not followed through. But his notebooks were careful. Date at the top. Headers underlined once. Important points marked with a small asterisk.

One evening in September, flipping back through his Financial Accounting notes to find a formula, he noticed something.

He had written her name.

Not in a significant way. It was in the margin of a page, small, next to a note that said *ask Ananya about the contra-entry doubt*. And on another page, *Ananya explained this — see page 28 of her notes*. And then, two pages further, not a note at all, just her name, written in his handwriting, as if his pen had wandered there on its own during a class when his attention had wandered the same direction.

He stared at it for a long moment.

Then he closed the notebook and put it on his desk and went to have dinner.

He didn't think about it after that. Or he tried not to. He was good at not thinking about things when not thinking about them was what was required. He had learned this as a child — his mother called it emotional

patience, and she said it was a gift. His father called it emotional stubbornness and said it would cause him trouble.

He had both of them in him. That was the truth.

The first semester moved in the way first semesters do — quickly at first, then slowly, then quickly again as exams approached. There were assignments and presentations and a unit test in Business Maths that the entire batch found brutal, and a Communication Skills submission that required them to give a five-minute speech in front of the class on any topic of their choice.

Ananya chose consumer behavior in modern India. She was nervous beforehand — he could tell because she spoke faster than usual in the canteen that morning, stopping mid-sentence twice. He listened and didn't say anything reassuring because she hadn't asked him to, but when she was done talking and looked at him with an expression that was trying to hide how worried she was, he said: "You know this topic better than you think. You just told me three good points without realizing."

She paused. Then she exhaled. "You heard that?"

"You were talking to me."

"I was talking at you. I wasn't sure you were listening."

"I was listening."

She went up and gave her speech, and it was good. Not perfect — she lost her thread once in the middle, glanced at her notes, and recovered — but it was clear and confident and real. He clapped when it was done, not loudly,

just normally. She came back to her seat and exhaled again, longer this time.

Dhruv's topic was behavioral economics. He had chosen it because it was adjacent to Ananya's topic and he thought it might be good to cover different angles of the same field for the class. He had not examined that impulse closely.

He spoke clearly and without flourish. He was not a performer — he didn't use his hands much, didn't walk around, didn't pause for effect. But he was precise, and he was honest about what he understood well and what he was still working out, and something in that honesty held the room.

Afterward, Ananya said: "You spoke like you were having a conversation with the class instead of presenting to them."

"Is that good?"

"Very good," she said.

They walked to the canteen. He ordered chai. She ordered chai and curd. He ate a samosa she talked him into and made his own resigned grimace and she laughed — actually laughed, her head tipping back slightly.

It was the first time he had made her laugh like that. Not a polite laugh or a quiet one. A real one.

He held that in his hands the whole walk home that evening, turning it over carefully, the way you handle something you're afraid of dropping.

Later, he opened his accounting notebook to study for the upcoming unit test. He found the page with her name in the margin. He looked at it. He

didn't close the notebook this time.

He sat there for a while, not studying, just thinking.

He wasn't in love with her. He told himself that, and at this point, it was probably still true. He was attached to her, yes. He noticed her more than he noticed other people, yes. But attachment was not love, and noticing was not longing, and this was just — college. This was just how friendships formed. This was completely ordinary.

He believed all of that. He believed it with the thorough conviction of someone who has a very strong reason to believe it.

Then he picked up his pen and went back to studying.

And his pen, twice more that evening, wandered to the margin of the page — and he pulled it back each time, almost in time, leaving only the faint ghost of a letter that could have been anything.

"He wrote her name in the margins of his notes the way rain writes on glass — without meaning to, but leaving a mark."

— CHAPTER FIVE

PART TWO

Falling

The Smile He Memorized

The first semester exams came and went, and with them, a holiday of three weeks during which Dhruv understood something he had been avoiding.

He missed her.

Not in a dramatic way. Not in the way characters in films missed people — lying on the floor, staring at the ceiling, unable to eat. He ate fine. He slept fine. He went to his cousin's wedding and sat through seventeen rounds of relatives asking him about his career plans. He helped his mother sort through old things in the store room. He finished a novel he'd been meaning to read since March.

But every day, at some point, he would think about something — a chai he had, the rain on Tuesday, a question about something he had read — and he would reach for his phone to tell her, and then stop. Not because he couldn't text her. They texted sometimes even during the break, brief things, study-related, a joke about their Economics professor who had told them, with great seriousness, that the supply curve was his "oldest friend."

He stopped because he was aware, suddenly and uncomfortably, of how often he wanted to. Of how many times a day he thought: *I should tell Ananya that.*

He tried to think about whether he did that with other people — Rohan, Sameer, Kavya. Did he regularly think *I should tell them that?*

The answer, honestly, was no.

He sat with that for a while. Then the three weeks ended, the second semester began, and he went back to college and walked into the classroom and she was already there, at her usual seat, talking to Priya, and she looked up and saw him and said, "Finally, someone I can complain to about the new seating arrangement."

And the thing in his chest — the small bird — moved. Just slightly. Like it had been waiting for him to come back too.

He took his seat. He said, "What's wrong with the seating arrangement?"

She explained. He listened. The class began.

He was in love with her. He knew it now.

He didn't say anything. He didn't do anything differently, at least not immediately. He let the knowledge sit inside him the way a stone sits at the bottom of a pond — completely submerged, not moving, not visible from the surface, but entirely there, and changing the weight of the water above it.

He noticed everything now.

He noticed the three different smiles she had. The first was the one she gave everyone — open, genuine, warm. The second was more specific — it appeared when she was amused by something she found genuinely clever, and it was smaller, only on one side, with the dimple. The third he hadn't quite named yet: it was the one she gave when she was worried but didn't want to show it, a smile that was present but slightly hollow in the middle, a smile that was doing work.

He noticed that she always sat slightly forward in her chair during classes she found interesting and slightly back in classes she found boring. He noticed that she tapped the table with two fingers when she was thinking. That she had a specific way of rolling her pen between her palms when she was reading something for the second time. That she ate faster when she was stressed and forgot to eat at all when she was genuinely absorbed in something.

He noticed all of this the way you notice things when someone has already become important to you before you understood what that meant.

He didn't tell her. Of course he didn't tell her.

He had no basis for telling her. She had never said anything, done anything, that suggested she thought of him as anything more than her closest friend in the B.Com batch — the person she studied with, ate with, walked across campus with. He was Dhruv. He was her canteen person, her library person, the one who helped her understand demand curves and told her she was better at speaking than she thought.

He was good at being that person. And she needed him to keep being that person.

So he stayed.

He listened. He helped. He remembered.

And underneath all of that — completely submerged, not moving — was the stone at the bottom of the pond.

*"He memorized her three smiles the way you memorize
an address you visit often enough that you no longer need
the directions."*

— CHAPTER SIX

Hazelnut Coffee

The college cafe was different from the canteen. The canteen was for lunch and chai breaks and quick samosas between classes. The cafe — a small room on the first floor that had been renovated two years ago by a student initiative and had, as a result, a slightly self-conscious aesthetic of exposed brick and chalkboard menus — was for sitting. For longer conversations. For the kind of afternoon that doesn't have an agenda.

In February of the second semester, Ananya discovered hazelnut coffee.

The cafe had recently started offering flavored coffee variants, and Ananya tried the hazelnut one on a Tuesday when she was in the mood for something different. She drank half of it with the expression of someone who suspects they might be making a terrible mistake, and then drank the second half with the expression of someone who has discovered something they might love forever.

"This is it," she said, holding the cup. "This is my drink."

Dhruv had ordered plain coffee. He tasted hers when she offered. It was sweet, slightly nutty, not something he would choose for himself. "You like that?"

"It's perfect. It tastes like a warm hug from a reasonable person."

"What does an unreasonable person's warm hug taste like?"

"Probably black coffee."

He laughed. He didn't laugh often, and it was usually quiet, but it was there — she had started getting those from him regularly now, small, surprised laughs that she clearly found encouraging, because she made more of the kind of jokes that produced them.

After that, he always knew what she would order in the cafe. He'd been there first a few times, and he'd ordered for both of them before she arrived, and her hazelnut coffee was always there waiting. She never asked him to do that. He just did it.

The first time, she sat down and looked at the cup and looked at him. "You ordered for me?"

"You always get the same thing."

"Still." She wrapped her hands around the cup. She had small hands — he had noticed this. She had a habit of holding warm things with both hands. "That's sweet."

"It's nothing," he said.

It wasn't nothing to him. He was aware of that. But he said it like it was, and he said it the way he did everything — without expectation, or at least without showing the expectation that was there.

That was the problem with Dhruv, if you were standing outside looking in. He was very good at hiding what he felt, and he had convinced himself that this hiding was kindness — that by not burdening her with what he felt, he

was being considerate. He was giving her the friendship without the weight of the feeling behind it.

What he didn't understand yet — what takes most people years to understand — is that feelings don't stay hidden. They change the texture of everything around them. The hazelnut coffee ordered in advance. The orange chair saved. The way he always happened to have a pen when she needed one, or to have read the chapter she hadn't gotten to yet, or to show up precisely when she was struggling.

None of it was nothing.

She wasn't blind. She saw it. But she filed it under *he's a very good friend*, because that was the honest category, and she was an honest person. She didn't examine it further, not because she was careless but because examining it would have meant having a conversation she wasn't sure how to have, and the friendship was working, and she valued it.

So they sat in the cafe that Tuesday with their coffees — plain and hazelnut — and she told him that she had applied for a workshop in the Economics department even though she wasn't sure she was ready for it, and he said she should go, and she said she was afraid she'd be the weakest person in the room, and he said that was probably true for everyone going in and that the whole point of the workshop was to become stronger, and she thought about that and said, "Okay, yes, that's true."

She went to the workshop. She came back two weeks later and told him it was one of the best things she'd done in college so far.

He listened and was glad.

He didn't say: *I knew you could do it*. He didn't say: *I told you*. He just listened and was glad, and that was enough.

For now, that was enough.

"He ordered her coffee before she arrived and called it nothing. But there is no such thing as nothing when you do it because you love someone."

— CHAPTER SEVEN

October Rain

The second year started in June, and by October it was raining the way only October can rain — not the aggressive monsoon rain of July, but something slower and more committed, the kind of rain that arrives in the morning and stays through the afternoon and has no particular urgency about anything.

The campus changed in the rain. The garden became briefly, intensely green. The fountain — still broken — filled with water that then spilled sideways, as it always did. The walkways between buildings became rivers of footsteps and wet umbrellas and the particular sound of raindrops hitting a tin roof in the distance.

Dhruv had a rain jacket. It was dark blue, somewhat old, and it worked. He was wearing it on the afternoon of the fifteenth when he found Ananya standing at the entrance of the library building, looking out at the rain with the expression of someone who has made a tactical error.

She had no umbrella. She had a bag full of notes she couldn't afford to get wet. She was calculating something — the distance to her hostel, the density of the rain, her options.

He stopped beside her. "Where do you need to go?"

"Hostel. It's a ten-minute walk."

He took off his rain jacket. It was large enough to cover her bag as well as her shoulders. "Here."

She looked at the jacket, then at him. He was wearing a full-sleeved cotton shirt that would be soaked through in about ninety seconds. "Dhruv —"

"It's not raining that hard."

"It's raining extremely hard."

"I'll be fine. I live ten minutes that way." He gestured in the opposite direction from the hostel. "Same distance, opposite direction. Take the jacket."

She looked at him for a moment. Then she took the jacket. She put it on — it was much too large, hanging past her hips — and picked up her bag. "I'll return it tomorrow."

"No rush."

"Thank you," she said. Not the quick, reflex kind of thank you. A real one, looking at him.

He walked home in the rain. He was soaked in four minutes. His shoes made squelching sounds the whole way. He was not bothered by any of this. He was, if anything, slightly lighter than he'd been in a while.

He knew that was irrational. He knew that getting soaked in the rain for someone who thought of you as a friend was not evidence of anything except that you were perhaps not very wise. He knew all of this and walked home in the rain and was lighter anyway.

She returned the jacket the next day. She had folded it, which he found disproportionately touching. Nobody had ever folded something of his before returning it.

"I also got you this," she said, and handed him a samosa from the canteen, wrapped in a newspaper square. "I know you think our samosas are too salty but this is a thank-you and you have to eat it."

He ate it. It was too salty. He didn't say so.

"Okay?" she asked, watching him.

"Good," he said.

She looked like she didn't entirely believe him but let it go. Then she said, "I have a theory about you."

"What theory?"

"You would lie about a samosa to protect someone's feelings but you would tell someone a hard truth when it mattered."

He thought about it. "That's probably accurate."

"That's a very specific combination of kindness and honesty."

"Or cowardice about small things and courage about big ones."

"Same thing, different angle," she said. She was smiling — the second smile, the smaller one. "I think I understand you a little now."

"Most people don't bother."

She tilted her head, a fraction. "That doesn't surprise me. You don't make it easy."

He wasn't sure whether that was a criticism. He decided it wasn't. "No," he said.

"I like puzzles," she said, simply, and walked ahead of him into the classroom.

He stood in the corridor for exactly one second longer than necessary.

Then he followed.

"He walked home in the rain and was lighter anyway. He knew that was irrational. He didn't care."

The rain continued through the week. On Friday morning, he found a note in his textbook — she had borrowed it the day before to photocopy a chapter she had missed. The note said: *You organize your books very nicely. Also your handwriting is too small.* — A

He kept the note. He put it in the inside pocket of his bag, where he kept his ID card and a spare pen.

He would keep it for two years after that, moving it from bag to bag when he changed them, without fully understanding why he didn't just throw it away. It was a nothing note. It said nothing. But it was from her, and her handwriting was in it, the round, deliberate handwriting of someone who had learned to write carefully, and it had an initial instead of a full name, like a small gift of shorthand.

He kept it. That was all.

*"He kept a note that said nothing because it was from her.
That is the arithmetic of loving someone — everything
ordinary becomes significant, everything light becomes
heavy."*

— CHAPTER EIGHT

Her Birthday

Ananya's birthday was November 23rd. Dhruv discovered this in September, two months before it, when she mentioned in passing that her sister had been born exactly eleven days before her and that their mother always claimed this was why they were so different — "She was born in Scorpio and I was born in Sagittarius, and Amma thinks astrology explains personality, which it doesn't, but she's not wrong about us being different."

"When is your birthday?" he asked.

"November 23rd. You?"

"March."

"Pisces?"

"Eighth. So yes, I think."

"My mother would have a lot to say about that," she said, and moved on to something else.

He noted the date in his phone. Under a reminder labeled simply: Nov 23.

He spent October and the first three weeks of November thinking about what to get her, in the slightly complicated way of someone who wants to do something meaningful without revealing the source of the meaning. He

couldn't get her something obviously romantic — flowers, for instance. He couldn't get her something that would invite questions. It had to be something that said: *I know you*, without saying: *I love you*.

He went to four shops. He ruled out: a pen set (too utilitarian), a book he had loved (too personal), a small plant (she didn't have a good window in her hostel room), a coffee mug (too ordinary). He ended up in a stationery store on a Saturday afternoon, and he found a notebook — not a college notebook, a personal one — with a cover the color of the sky just after sunset, that deep blue that isn't quite night yet. On the inside front cover, the store had a small stamp that said: *write what you mean*.

He bought it.

Then he went to a bakery and ordered a single slice of chocolate cake in a small box, because she had mentioned once that she didn't eat big amounts of cake but always wanted a taste of it.

On November 23rd, he arrived at college slightly earlier than usual. He was at his desk when she came in, and she was surprised to see him there — he was usually the one who arrived exactly on time. She sat down, pulled off her scarf, and said, "You're early."

"I know."

Then he took the notebook and the small box from his bag and put them on her desk. Just that. No speech, no ceremony.

She looked at them. Then at him. "Is that —"

"Happy birthday."

She was quiet for a moment. Then she picked up the notebook and looked at the cover. The exact-right-blue cover. She turned it over. Read the stamp inside. Set it down and picked up the cake box and opened it and saw the single chocolate slice.

"How did you remember?" she said.

"You told me in September."

"I told you in passing."

"I remember things."

She looked at him. Her expression had shifted — not dramatically, not into something easy to name. It was soft, and slightly wondering, and he was afraid for one second that it meant something different from what it actually meant, that she was going to say something that he wasn't ready for.

But she just said: "Thank you, Dhruv." Quietly. Like the words had weight.

"It's nothing," he said. His standard answer.

"It isn't," she said.

At lunch, Priya and Riyahad organized a small gathering in the cafe — a few friends, a larger piece of cake that did have candles, and a group rendition of Happy Birthday that was enthusiastic if not exactly tuneful. Ananya laughed through all of it, genuinely happy, turning to include everyone.

She turned to Dhruv at one point and said, to the table: "He got me a single slice of chocolate cake because I once told him I only ever want a taste."

Priya raised her eyebrows at him across the table.

He looked at his chai.

Kavya said, "Dhruv, that's very thoughtful."

"It's nothing," he said. Third time.

Ananya shook her head but didn't argue. She cut the cafe's cake and passed pieces around and ate her birthday lunch surrounded by friends, and she carried the small blue notebook in her hands for the rest of the afternoon, as if she hadn't decided yet where to put it down.

That evening, she sent him a message: *I'm going to write things in the notebook. Important ones. Thank you for knowing what that means.*

He read it four times.

He typed: *Happy birthday.*

He put his phone down. He looked at the ceiling of his room for a long time.

Then he picked up his own notebook — his accounting one — and opened it to a fresh page, and at the top, where he usually wrote the date, he wrote: November 23.

And nothing after that. Just the date. Just her date.

He closed it and went to sleep.

"The most loving thing he ever gave her cost almost nothing. She kept it for years. He never told her why he chose that particular blue."

— CHAPTER NINE

Group Project

In March of the second year, the Business Economics professor announced a group project. Topic: *Market Structures in the Indian Service Sector*. Groups of five. Self-selected. Submission in six weeks.

The classroom became briefly chaotic. Everyone turned to look at their friends. Alliances were quickly established. People who had been sitting two rows apart suddenly discovered they were in the same group.

Ananya turned to him. "Us?"

"Yes."

"Who else? We need three more."

They gathered Sameer, who had a laptop with a good presentation software, Kavya, who was terrifying at research, and a quiet boy named Vivek who sat near the window and had the best marks in the class and was generally humble about it in a way that made him easy to like.

The group of five met for the first time on a Saturday at the college library, at the big table near the back that could fit all of them. They divided the topic, made a timeline, assigned sections. It was all slightly formal at first — the getting-to-know-you professionalism of people who are mostly strangers except for pairs among them.

By the third meeting, the formality was gone.

Kavya dominated the research and made charts that were more detailed than anyone had asked for. Sameer tried to make the presentation beautiful, which led to a forty-minute discussion about font size that nobody had anticipated. Vivek contributed quietly and consistently. Ananya coordinated, kept track of who had done what, remembered deadlines, sent reminder messages.

Dhruv wrote.

He had, it turned out, a talent for turning complicated information into clear language. Kavya would come in with twelve points of data and he would read it and pull out the three that actually mattered and write them in sentences that anyone could understand. It wasn't showy. It was just effective. Kavya would say, reading his section, "Yes, that's exactly what I meant, how did you say it better than I did?"

Ananya noticed. She always noticed.

"You should write more," she told him one evening when it was just the two of them in the library finishing the final draft while the others had gone home. "Not just assignments. Actually write."

"Write what?"

"Whatever. You have a way with words. It would be a waste not to."

He looked at her. "I write things," he said carefully.

"Like what?"

He didn't answer that. He went back to the draft instead. She let it go, but he felt her looking at him for a moment before she did, and he was aware

that she had noticed him not answering, and that she had decided not to push.

That was one of the things he valued most about her. She had very good instincts about when not to push.

They submitted the project on a Wednesday. The professor gave them a distinction, which Kavya celebrated by buying everyone in the group kulfi from the canteen and posting about it on the department's WhatsApp group. Sameer made a joke. Vivek smiled, pleased and modest as always. Ananya said, "To the best-looking presentation in the batch," which made Sameer beam.

She turned to Dhruv. "And to the best-written analysis."

"To the person who actually organized everything," he said, deflecting back to her.

"We're all complimenting each other. This is lovely." She raised her kulfi like a toast. "To the group."

They raised their kulfis. Someone dripped on the table. Kavya complained. Sameer laughed. It was late afternoon, the light from the canteen window long and golden, and the five of them were briefly, completely happy in the way that only happens in college, when the smallest wins feel enormous and the company is right and nobody is thinking about what comes after.

Dhruv looked around the table. He looked at each of them — Sameer's wide grin, Kavya's theatrical sighing, Vivek's quiet pleasure, and Ananya, who had her hands wrapped around her kulfi and was laughing at something Kavya said, her head tilting back, that full laugh, the unreserved one.

He thought: I want to remember this exactly like this.

He looked at it as long as he could. Then he ate his kulfi and laughed at the next thing Kavya said, and was present, and was with all of them.

But underneath it all, he was filing it away. Every detail. The light, the table, the sound, the way she laughed. All of it, stored carefully in the place where he kept everything that mattered to him.

"He memorized the moment while he was still living it — because somewhere inside him, he already knew this was the kind of happiness that doesn't stay."

— CHAPTER TEN

PART THREE

Almost

What People Said

People started saying things in the second year. It began with Sameer, which was almost predictable, because Sameer said almost everything before it was ready to be said. He had a personality that ran slightly ahead of the moment, which was charming most of the time and occasionally too much.

They were sitting in the canteen — all five of them, plus two of Ananya's friends from Section B — when Sameer said, in the general direction of no one: "I feel like Dhruv and Ananya should just date. Like, can someone say it? I'll say it."

He said it.

The table went briefly, distinctly quiet.

Kavya looked at her chai. Vivek became extremely interested in his notes. The Section B friends exchanged a quick glance. Dhruv looked at his plate. Ananya looked at Sameer with an expression that was neither amused nor alarmed — something calmer than both, the expression of someone who has heard a thing and is deciding how to handle it.

"We're friends, Sameer," she said. Even-voiced. Not embarrassed, not annoyed. Just clear.

"I know, I know. I'm just saying. The vibe." Sameer made a gesture. "The vibe is there."

"The vibe is friendship," she said. She smiled — the first smile, the one she gave everyone — and moved the conversation forward to something else, and it went, because she was good at steering conversations.

But Dhruv had been watching her when Sameer said it, and he had seen the split second before she answered. The half-moment where her expression did something — not what he wanted it to do, not a flash of something hidden and hopeful. Just a thoughtful pause. A measuring look. A careful calculation.

She wasn't considering saying yes. She was figuring out how to say no kindly. He saw that. He was good at seeing things.

He ate the rest of his lunch and felt the stone at the bottom of the pond shift, very slightly. Not move. Just settle differently. Just press a little harder against the ground.

After that, the comments were occasional. Not constant — most people didn't pay that much attention to other people's lives, especially not in the organized chaos of a college year. But it came up. A professor made a mild observation about "the two of you always in the same row." A senior who knew them both asked if they were "a thing." One of Ananya's hostel friends sent a message to the group chat asking if Dhruv was "the guy Ananya's always with" and whether they were "you know."

Ananya's answer was always the same. Patient, clear, unembellished. Friends.

And she never said it awkwardly. That was the thing. She didn't look at him when she said it, to check if he was hurt. She didn't preface it with *oh no no no*. She just said it like it was a simple fact, which, to her, it was.

He understood that. He also felt, each time, something that he couldn't call pain exactly, because it was too diffuse for that, too spread out. More like the feeling of a word that's on the tip of your tongue — present, almost-there, never quite arriving.

In April, Priya asked him about it directly. Priya was direct by nature and kind by nature, and the combination made her someone who could ask difficult questions without it feeling like an attack.

They were both waiting outside the exam hall for it to open, Ananya was inside doing something or other, and Priya said, "Can I ask you something personal?"

"Okay," he said.

"Do you have feelings for Ananya?"

He was quiet for a moment. Then he said, "She's my closest friend."

Priya looked at him with the calm patience of someone who has asked a question and received a different answer. "I asked if you have feelings for her."

"I know what you asked."

Another pause. She nodded slowly. She had her answer. She filed it away without making him say it out loud, which was a kindness he was grateful for.

"Okay," she said. "For what it's worth — she talks about you all the time. Not like that. But you're important to her. Genuinely."

"I know," he said.

"But not like that."

"I know," he said again.

She nodded. Then she said, gently: "I just don't want either of you to get hurt."

He looked at her. He thought about what to say. He said, "I'm fine, Priya."

She looked like she had doubts about that. But she didn't push. That was the difference between Priya and Sameer: Priya said the hard thing once and let it land, and then moved on. She trusted people to do something with the information.

The exam hall opened. They filed in. He found his seat, opened his paper, and answered all four sections. He did well, as he always did when he was thorough, and he was thorough in the exam because being thorough was the only thing he had full control over.

"She said 'we're friends' the way you state a fact about the weather — matter-of-factly, without cruelty, and without knowing that every time she said it, someone was revising something inside him."

The College Festival

Meghna College's annual cultural festival was called Tarang, which meant wave, which seemed appropriate for something that swept through the whole campus for three days and left everything rearranged in its wake.

It happened in October of the second year, and by October, Dhruv had been carrying what he felt for Ananya for almost a year and a half. He had gotten good at it the way you get good at carrying something heavy — not by making it lighter, but by adjusting your posture around it, redistributing the weight so that you could move normally even though it was there.

Tarang preparation started three weeks early. The drama club was rehearsing in the auditorium every evening. The music society had commandeered a practice room. Various departments were planning stalls. There were auditions for the singing competition, tryouts for the dance show, a film screening, a debate, and something called the Meghna Open Mic that was described on the posters as a "celebration of diverse voices and creative courage."

Ananya, it turned out, could sing.

Dhruv didn't know this until she mentioned it, offhandedly, during a canteen lunch in September, that she was thinking about signing up for the singing competition. He asked if she sang. She said she used to sing at her school and at home, classical mainly, but she was rusty. He said she should

sign up anyway. She said she didn't know if she was good enough. He said she'd never know if she didn't try. She gave him a look that was equal parts grateful and suspicious, like he was making a point at her expense.

She signed up.

She practiced in the evenings in the practice room, sometimes alone, sometimes with the music teacher. Dhruv heard her once, completely by accident, passing the practice room on his way from the library. The door was ajar. He stopped. She was singing a Hindustani classical piece — something slow and measured and precise, the kind of music that requires patience, that takes years to develop the control for. And she had it. The control, the reach, the stillness in the voice that only comes when someone has learned how to be quiet inside while their voice does something moving.

He stood in the corridor for almost two minutes. Then he walked away before she finished, because if she saw him there it would require an explanation, and any explanation he gave would be technically true and emotionally complicated.

On the first day of Tarang, the campus was a different place. Colored lights had been strung along the walkways. Stalls sold food and craft items. A DJ was playing in the courtyard. Students from other colleges had come, which made everything louder and slightly more electric. The air smelled of fried food and floral perfume and the particular excitement of a crowd in a good mood.

He walked through it with Ananya and Sameer and Kavya and Vivek, moving from stall to stall, eating street food that wasn't quite as good as the actual street version but was enhanced by the festival atmosphere. They played a ring toss and all lost embarrassingly. They watched the opening

dance performance from the third row and agreed afterward that the second half was better than the first.

The singing competition was on day two.

Dhruv arrived early enough to get a seat in the fifth row. He sat between Sameer and Kavya. Ananya was backstage. She had sent him one message that morning: *I'm going to embarrass myself aren't I*. He had sent back: *No*. She had sent back: *That was fast. You didn't even think about it*. He had sent: *I don't need to think about it*. She had sent a single emoji — the kind with one eye squinting. He had put his phone down.

Eight students competed. Three were clearly trained. Two were brave beginners. Two were somewhere in between. And then there was Ananya, who walked onstage in a dark green kurta, looked at the audience with the expression of someone who has made a decision and is committed to it, adjusted the microphone, and sang.

She sang Yaman. A slow, deliberate alap first, then a composition she had chosen. Her voice was controlled, warm, doing things that only happen when someone has worked at something long enough that the technique becomes invisible — all you hear is the music itself.

The auditorium was quiet in a different way than when other people sang. Not politely quiet — actually quiet. The kind of quiet where people stop moving because movement would interrupt something.

Dhruv didn't move.

He watched her, onstage under the light, her eyes slightly closed during the difficult passages, her shoulders still, her voice finding each note with the

certainty of someone who has found this place many times before and knows exactly how to arrive.

She came second in the competition, behind a girl from the music department who had been training since childhood. The announcement was made and the room clapped, and Ananya came back to find them with her certificate rolled up and her face flushed with something between relief and joy.

"Second place," Sameer said, immediately calculating. "That means you're officially good."

"First place means you're officially good. Second means you're good but someone is better."

"That's the definition of second in general, yes," Kavya said.

Ananya was laughing. She turned to Dhruv. "You look like you have something to say."

"You knew that was going to happen," he said.

"What?"

"You knew you were that good. You were nervous, but you knew."

She paused. Then she smiled — the second smile, the smaller one. "Maybe. But I needed someone to tell me to go find out."

She said it simply, without extra weight. But he held it for the rest of the evening, standing in the festival crowd, watching the lights and the people and the movement all around him.

He thought: this is enough. Being here like this. This should be enough.

It wasn't enough, but he tried to make it be.

"She sang like she had made peace with something. He watched her and understood that the thing she'd made peace with was not him."

— CHAPTER TWELVE

Late Night Calls

It started during exam season.

In November of the second year, with the semester exams approaching, Ananya and Dhruv began calling each other in the evenings. Not every evening — maybe four times a week. Late, after ten, when the noise in the hostel died down and the library was closed and both of them were sitting at their respective desks with their notes and their exhaustion.

She would call him. That was how it went. She would call and he would pick up, and she would say something like "okay explain opportunity cost to me one more time" and he would, and then the explanation would turn into a conversation, and the conversation would turn into something less structured, and by midnight they would be talking about things that had nothing to do with economics.

These calls were not what he wanted them to be. He knew that. They were study calls that drifted. They were practical things with an emotional texture that came from friendship, not from anything else. He knew this with complete clarity, the way he knew most things: intellectually, precisely, and slightly helplessly.

But they were also the thing he looked forward to most.

He would finish dinner and sit at his desk and wait, in a way that he was careful never to call waiting. He would open his books. He would study. And at some point between ten and ten-thirty, his phone would ring and her

name would appear on the screen and something in him would ease, like a breath held for a long time finally released.

Their longest call that month lasted until 1:47 in the morning. They had started with a question about financial ratios and ended somewhere near the topic of what she missed about Nagpur — the specific afternoon light there, she said, the way it came through the windows of her grandmother's house and landed on the floor in long rectangular patches that she used to sit in as a child. She told him about her grandmother's house in detail: the kitchen that smelled of fenugreek, the old-style courtyard, the mango tree that had been there since before anyone in the family was born.

He listened to all of it. He didn't interrupt. And at the end, when she said "sorry, I don't know why I'm telling you all this," he said, "I asked."

"You didn't ask about my grandmother's house."

"I asked about Nagpur. That's where your grandmother's house is."

She was quiet for a moment. "You're easy to talk to," she said.

"You just said more words in the last twenty minutes than most people say in an hour."

"You made a safe space for the words."

He didn't know what to do with that sentence, so he said nothing. She yawned — he heard it clearly — and said she should sleep, she had an 8:30 class. He said he also had an 8:30 class. She laughed. They said goodnight and hung up.

He put his phone face-down on the desk and stared at the textbook he hadn't been reading. He sat there for a while.

There is a kind of hope that doesn't announce itself. It doesn't say: I think this might work out. It just keeps showing up, keeps doing what it does, keeps being present and warm and close, and it tells itself that presence is not the same as expectation.

But it is. Eventually, all presence becomes expectation. You can only be there so many times before you start to feel that being there entitles you to something. Not as a demand. Not even as a conscious thought. Just as a feeling that grows slowly, in the space between all the giving, the quiet assumption: surely, eventually, this will matter. Surely eventually this will tip.

He didn't know he was building this. He thought he was only being a friend. He thought being a good friend was enough, was the right thing, was the noble thing.

He didn't see yet what the hope was doing to him. How it was changing the structure of things underneath, quietly, the way water changes stone: too slowly to see, too constantly to stop.

He opened his textbook. He studied until three. He fell asleep at his desk and woke up at seven with his face on his notes and the particular disorientation of someone who slept in the wrong position but dreamed something good.

He couldn't remember the dream. But he woke up still feeling it, warm and confused in equal measure.

He got up, made tea, and went to his 8:30 class.

She was already there, in her usual seat. She looked tired. She had her coffee — hazelnut, from the college cafe, she must have gone before class. When he sat down, she said without looking up from her notes: "I told you about my grandmother's house last night."

"Yes."

"I'm a little embarrassed."

"Don't be."

She looked up at him. He was looking at the front of the room, waiting for the professor. She looked at him for a moment with something he couldn't identify in her expression, something between gratitude and something more complex. Then she looked back at her notes.

"Okay," she said. And that was the end of it.

"He looked forward to her calls the way some people look forward to rain — hoping for it without admitting it, relieved every time it came."

— CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Trip

In January of the third year, the department organized a two-day educational trip to Mahabaleshwar. Thirty-two students, two buses, one set of professors who were visibly more relaxed than they were in college, and an itinerary that used the word "educational" generously to describe what was mostly a mountain trip with a worksheet attached.

Dhruv's mother packed him a bag with more food than he could eat in four days. He removed two-thirds of it and replaced it with a book, a notebook, and the rain jacket that had become his standard equipment since October of the previous year.

The bus left at six in the morning, and by six-fifteen, most of the batch was asleep. Dhruv was awake. He was always awake in the mornings. He looked out the window as the city gave way to highway, and the highway curved into the foothills, and the foothills climbed into something greener and colder.

Ananya was sitting two rows ahead with Priya. He could see the back of her head. She was awake too — he could tell from the slight movement of her shoulders and the occasional gesture of her hand when she was talking. Priya was asleep beside her.

At around nine, the bus stopped at a dhaba for chai and breakfast. Everyone filed off, slightly groggy, into the cold mountain air that smelled of

eucalyptus and damp earth. The fog was sitting low on the hills, and through it the shapes of trees appeared and disappeared.

He got chai and stood with it at the edge of the dhaba's concrete platform, looking out at the valley. It was the kind of view that makes you quiet — not because it's overwhelming, but because it's so completely its own thing that your thoughts have nowhere to land on it. You just look.

She appeared beside him with her own chai — he could smell it before she arrived, the faint sweetness of it.

"Not sleeping?" she said.

"I don't sleep on buses."

"Why not?"

"I think I'm afraid I'll miss something."

She looked at the view. "Like this."

"Like this."

They stood together without talking for a while. The fog moved. A bird called from somewhere in it, once, twice, then stopped. The chai was strong and too hot and he drank it anyway.

"I want to live in a place that looks like this someday," she said.

"In the fog?"

"Near it. Near mountains. Or somewhere with a lot of trees."

"Nagpur has a lot of trees."

"It has a lot of heat. The trees are incidental." She paused. "I think I'd like to live near something bigger than me. Something that reminds me that I'm small in the good way."

He looked at her. "The good way?"

"Small in the sense of — there's so much more than my specific problems. Small in the sense of, look at this, nothing I'm worried about right now matters at all in front of this."

He looked back at the valley. "I understand that."

"You probably already feel that way," she said. "You always seem to have something in perspective."

"I don't," he said.

"You seem like you do."

"Seeming is different from having."

She looked at him for a moment. That look again — the careful, slightly puzzled one she reserved for when he said something that surprised her. "What don't you have in perspective, Dhruv?"

He was quiet. The valley was full of fog. He drank his chai. He said, "Some things."

She didn't push. She knew better. She went back to looking at the view.

That afternoon, the group went to a viewpoint where they could see two valleys converging at a curve of river below. Someone produced a football from somewhere and a game started on the flat ground near the parking area. Others took photographs. The professors sat at a tea stall and talked to each other like humans for the first time.

Dhruv sat on a low wall near the edge and wrote in his notebook. Not notes. Not assignments. Just — things. Observations. The color of the sky at this altitude, which was different from the city color, more saturated, more final. The sound of the group's game carrying across the clear air. The way fog moved through a valley, not like water, not quite like smoke, something in between.

Ananya sat beside him at some point. She had a mango slice from a vendor she'd found somewhere. She ate it without commenting on the sourness, which told him she liked sour things.

"What are you writing?" she asked.

"Nothing important."

"You always say that."

"It's always true."

She leaned slightly — not enough to read, just enough to register the presence of words on the page. He didn't move the notebook. She sat back. "Okay," she said.

They sat side by side on the wall and watched the valley and the game and the fog, and the afternoon passed around them like a river around two rocks that have decided to stay.

That evening, the group had dinner at the resort — a buffet, loud, chaotic, full of the particular happiness of thirty students let out of their normal context. Dhruv ate and talked and watched. Kavya started a singalong with some of the boys. Sameer told a story about his auto-rickshaw driver uncle that was either embellished or miraculous, nobody could tell.

Ananya was across the table, talking to Priya about something, laughing at something. She caught his eye once, across the table and the noise, and smiled — not any of the three particular smiles he had catalogued. Something new, something simpler: the smile you give across a crowded room to someone when you're both in it but haven't had a chance to talk. The smile that means: *I see you there. I know you're there. Isn't this something?*

He smiled back. Small, quiet. The way he did everything.

That night, in the room he shared with Sameer and Vivek, after Sameer had fallen asleep dramatically and Vivek was reading, Dhruv lay on his cot in the dark and thought about that smile. Not analyzed it — just held it. Turned it over. Felt the weight of it in his chest.

He thought: I will remember this trip for a long time.

He was right. He did.

"She smiled at him from across a crowded room the way you smile at something that belongs to you. She didn't know that's how it looked. He didn't know how to unlook it."

— CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Study Season

March of the third year was the last semester's study season, and it was the cruelest.

Not because of the volume — they had done this twice before, the six weeks before finals when everything compressed and the days became textbooks and chai and the particular desperation of trying to absorb a semester's worth of learning in a fraction of its time. They had done this. They knew how to do this.

But this time there was an extra weight. The awareness that this was the last time. That after these exams, the three years would be over. That the campus and the canteen and the library and table seven would belong to them for only a few more weeks.

Nobody said this out loud. But it was in the air. You could feel it in the way people took photographs more often, and stayed after class to talk instead of leaving immediately, and lingered at the canteen table an extra twenty minutes even when they had studying to do.

Dhruv felt it more than most.

He and Ananya spent a lot of time in the library that March. The second window table, right side, like always. But now they both studied more seriously — he with his accounting texts, she with her economics, each absorbed in their own material but present to the other's presence.

Sometimes they didn't speak for two hours at a time. He would look up from his notes occasionally and find her reading, her pen moving in small annotations, her face concentrated. He would look for a moment, then look back at his own work.

During breaks, they talked. About what came after, mostly. She was applying for MBA programs, as she had always planned. She had a shortlist of five colleges and had been working on her applications since December. She was methodical about it — the same way she was methodical about everything she cared about.

He was less certain. He had thought about a CA, thought about an MBA, thought about joining a family friend's business to learn the trade from inside. He hadn't decided. He told her this honestly.

"You'll figure it out," she said. "You always do, eventually."

"You say that like I have a history of figuring things out."

"You do. You're just quiet about it. You work things out inside and then the answer appears."

"That's not how decisions usually work."

"For most people, no. For you —" She shrugged. "For you it seems to."

He looked at his textbook. He thought: *Not all things*. He thought: *Some things I've been working out for two and a half years and the answer keeps not appearing*.

He said none of this. He asked her about the MBA applications instead.

They worked until 5:30, when the library staff began the subtle process of making people aware that closing time was approaching — dimming one set of lights, moving chairs, the particular pointed clearing of a throat.

They walked down the stairs together. Through the corridor, past the notice board — still as dense as ever, the layers of paper now including farewell party announcements and graduation photo offers and one aggressively large poster for someone's final-year film project. Out into the campus, which at this hour was golden and slightly quieter, the crowd thinned to people with specific reasons to still be there.

They walked to the gate. His route home went left. Her bus stop went right.

They had done this a hundred times. Maybe more. The parting at the gate, the slight pause, the see-you-tomorrow or the see-you-after-exams or just see-you, and then they went their separate ways and he walked home thinking about her and she took the bus thinking about whatever she thought about, which was probably not him in the same way.

This time, she stopped at the gate and turned to him and said, "Dhruv."

"Mm."

"I'm really glad you were the person I sat next to on the first day."

He looked at her. She was looking at him with an expression that was completely genuine — not weighted, not leading anywhere. Just true.

"Me too," he said.

She smiled. Nodded. "Okay. Study hard. I'll see you Thursday."

"Thursday," he said.

She went right. He went left. He walked two blocks before he realized he hadn't blinked in quite a while, and his eyes were slightly dry, and the street in front of him was blurring slightly at the edges in a way that had nothing to do with the light.

He blinked. He kept walking.

He was, he understood clearly now, running out of time. Not to tell her — he had ruled that out, quietly and completely, somewhere in the past year. He was running out of time with her, with this specific version of both of them, this particular configuration of closeness that college had made possible and that the end of college would unmake.

He was running out of time to simply be near her like this, in the ordinary way, without it being an effort, without it requiring a plan.

He walked home in the evening light and held that knowledge very carefully, the way you hold something that is already breaking.

*"The saddest kind of ending is the one that arrives
without warning, wearing the face of an ordinary
evening."*

— CHAPTER FIFTEEN

PART FOUR

The Weight



Keeping Score

Something changed in the second semester of the third year that Dhruv didn't notice immediately, but that would become, in time, the thing he was most ashamed of when he looked back.

He started keeping score.

Not deliberately. Not consciously. He didn't sit down with a ledger. But the counting started somewhere in his mind, without permission, and once it started, he couldn't unhear it.

He noticed when he had canceled his plans to help her with a presentation and she hadn't thanked him. He noticed when she made plans with Priya on a day she had originally said she'd spend in the library with him. He noticed when she messaged other people in the group chat before she messaged him. He noticed when she came to the canteen with Riya and forgot to save the orange chair, and he had to sit at a different table.

These were small things. He knew they were small things. He had always known that friendship was not a contract, that people made and changed plans, that she didn't owe him any particular arrangement of her time. He had known this clearly and completely.

But the score kept being counted.

The problem with loving someone and not telling them is that the love builds up somewhere it has no outlet. It has to go somewhere. And in

Dhruv, it began going into a register of what he had given and what he had received, and the two columns did not balance, had never balanced, and he began to feel the imbalance.

He said nothing about it directly. He was still the same person on the surface — quiet, reliable, there. But underneath, a change was happening, the way a pipe changes before it breaks: not visible yet, but under pressure, and for longer than it was designed for.

The first time it came out, it was small.

She had forgotten a book he had lent her — his advanced accounting reference, which he had given her for a weekend and which she hadn't returned for two weeks, because she'd gotten busy, and it had slipped her mind.

He brought it up gently. She apologized immediately, genuinely: "I'm so sorry, I completely forgot. I'll bring it tomorrow."

"It's fine," he said. "I just needed it for the unit test prep."

"When is the test?"

"Monday."

A pause. "Dhruv, why didn't you ask earlier?"

"I thought you'd remember."

She looked at him. "You should have just asked. I didn't know you needed it."

"I told you when I lent it."

"That was two weeks ago. I have a lot going on right now." Her tone was patient, but there was something slightly careful in it — the tone of someone being patient with someone who is making a small thing large. "I'll get it to you tomorrow morning, okay? I promise."

She brought it the next morning. She held it out with a note stuck to the cover that said *sorry again* in her handwriting. He took the book and the note and said it was fine.

It was fine. That was the truth. But something in the way it had gone — the way she'd suggested he should have reminded her, instead of simply apologizing without the addition — had landed in the register. Had added one more item to the column that was not balancing.

He didn't examine this. He didn't ask himself whether his expectation was fair. He only felt the weight of the imbalance, and the weight was growing, and he carried it the way he'd always carried things: quietly, alone, without telling anyone, without being entirely sure himself that it was there.

The trouble with unexpressed love is that it doesn't stay unexpressed. It finds its way out in the shape of other things. Expectations. Silences. The slight withdrawal that happens when someone feels unseen. He had thought he was protecting her from his feelings by not naming them. He hadn't understood that an unnamed thing doesn't disappear. It transforms.

He was transforming, slowly, and he didn't see it. And she didn't see it either, not yet. They were still close, still easy together, still going to the library and the canteen and talking about everything.

But the weight was there.

And things under weight eventually crack.

"He never planned to keep score. But when you love someone who doesn't know it, every small thing becomes evidence of something. Every forgotten detail becomes a verdict."

— CHAPTER SIXTEEN

When He Said Too Much

It happened on a Wednesday evening in the library, mid-March, six weeks before the final exams.

He had been at the window table since three. He had been waiting for her since four, when she had texted to say she was on her way. By 4:45, she hadn't arrived. By 5:15, he had texted: *Still coming?* She had replied: *Sorry! Priya needed help with something. Coming now.*

She arrived at 5:30. She sat down, pulled out her notes, said sorry again, and started studying.

He said nothing.

For twenty minutes, they studied in silence. Then she looked up and said, "You're quiet. More than usual."

"I'm studying."

She watched him for a moment. "Are you upset?"

"No."

"Dhruv."

He put down his pen. He looked at the table. He said, "I've been here since three."

She blinked. "I know. I said I was sorry."

"I canceled a meeting with Sameer because I thought we were studying together."

"I didn't know that." Her voice was level. "You didn't tell me you had something else."

"I didn't have anything else. I moved something to be here."

"Dhruv, I said I was sorry. Priya needed help and it took longer than I expected. That happens."

"It keeps happening," he said. He heard it as he said it — the score, the register, the thing that had been building for months, arriving in his voice without his full permission.

Ananya set down her pen. She looked at him carefully, with the look of someone who is paying close attention because the conversation has just become something different from what it appeared to be. "What keeps happening?"

"Nothing." He picked up his pen. "It's nothing. Forget it."

"No, you said something. Tell me."

He was quiet for a moment. Then he said, carefully, "I just feel like — I'm always the one who shows up. I cancel things. I plan around your schedule. And when something small comes up on your end, it's fine to change the plan."

She absorbed this. She didn't react immediately. She looked at him with an expression he couldn't quite read — not angry, not defensive, something more careful. "Have I asked you to cancel things for me?"

"No."

"Have I asked you to plan around my schedule?"

"No."

"Then —" she paused. Chose her words. "Dhruv, if you made those decisions, that's not something I can be responsible for. I didn't ask for that."

He said nothing. She was right. He knew she was right, completely and clearly. She had never asked him for any of it. Every coffee ordered early, every rain jacket given, every plan shifted — all of it had come from him, freely, without request. He had no claim.

"I know," he said. "I know you didn't ask."

"Then why are you —" She stopped. Started again, more gently. "Are you okay? Is something else going on?"

"No."

"Because you're not — this doesn't sound like you."

He looked at her. And something in him wanted to say it — all of it, finally, the whole thing that had been sitting under the surface for two and a half years. He wanted to say: *I'm in love with you and I have been since the second semester of first year and I have given you everything I had and I*

don't know how to do this anymore, I don't know how to keep watching you not know, I don't know how to keep being beside you without being with you, I'm tired, I'm so tired.

He didn't say it.

He said: "I'm sorry. I'm stressed about exams. It came out wrong."

She looked at him for a moment longer. Then she nodded, slowly. She picked up her pen. "Okay," she said.

They went back to studying. The silence was different now — not the easy kind. The kind with a shape to it. The kind where things have been said and unsaid and both remain, somehow, in the air.

At six, she packed up her notes and said she had to go. She said it normally. She said goodbye normally. But at the door of the library, she looked back at him for one second with something in her expression that might have been concern, or might have been the first faint understanding of something she hadn't understood before.

He looked back. He tried to smile. It wasn't quite a smile but it was as close as he could get.

She left.

He sat at the window table until the library closed, not studying, looking at the garden outside where the last light was going orange and then grey, and thinking about nothing useful, and feeling like something had cracked — not broken, not yet, but cracked — and that the cracking was the beginning of an ending he wasn't ready for.

"He said too much and not enough, and both were true at the same time, and neither fixed anything."

— CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

What She Didn't Say

She knew something. She had known something for a long time, actually — not as a certainty, but as a shape in her peripheral vision, something she had been careful not to look at directly because looking at it would require her to do something about it, and she had not known what to do.

She talked to Priya about it after the library evening. Not immediately — she went back to the hostel and ate dinner and did an hour of studying and then, when Priya came to her room to borrow a highlighter, she said: "Can I talk to you about something?"

Priya put the highlighter down. "Yes."

"I think Dhruv might —" she started, then stopped. "I think Dhruv has feelings for me. More than friendship."

Priya said, very evenly: "Yes."

Ananya looked at her. "You knew?"

"I knew about eight months ago. He didn't tell me. I figured it out."

"Why didn't you —"

"Because you needed to figure it out yourself. And because telling you what someone else feels is his job, not mine."

Ananya was quiet for a moment. "He hasn't said anything."

"I know."

"He's never said anything explicit. He just —" she stopped. How did you name it? The coffee ordered early. The rain jacket. The birthday present. The way he listened. The way he always knew. "He just does things," she said. "And I've let him, because it was kind, and I appreciated it, and I thought — I thought we were just close friends, and some close friends are like that."

"That's true," Priya said, gently. "Some friends are like that. And maybe that's all it is. But today, in the library —"

"He was upset. Not in an obvious way. But he was keeping track of things."

"Of things he'd done for you?"

"I think so. Yes." Ananya looked at her hands. "I haven't done anything wrong. I haven't promised anything. But —"

"But?" Priya said.

"But I feel guilty. And I don't know if I should feel guilty. Because I didn't ask him to do any of it. And I've been honest — whenever anyone asked, I said we were friends. I've never been anything else to him."

"You haven't done anything wrong," Priya confirmed. "But that doesn't mean he isn't hurting."

"I know." She put her hands in her lap. "Priya, I don't feel that way about him. I've thought about it. Not lately, but — before, when people used to say

things, I would think about it. And I care about him deeply. He's one of the most important people I've ever had in my life. But not that way. It's just not there."

"You don't have to explain yourself," Priya said quietly. "Feelings aren't logic. You feel what you feel."

"I know. But I feel terrible."

"I know you do."

They sat together in the quiet. Outside, the hostel was its usual noise — voices down the corridor, music from somewhere, the sound of someone's bucket against the floor. Ordinary sounds. Nothing had changed and everything was slightly different.

"Should I say something to him?" Ananya asked.

"Do you know what you'd say?"

"I'd say — I'd say I care about him. That he's important. That I don't want to lose what we have. And that I —" she stopped again. "I'd have to be honest. Which means saying something that will hurt him."

"Yes," Priya said.

"But he hasn't said anything. So there's nothing to respond to. If I say something now, I'm assuming. And if I assume wrong, I've created a problem that didn't exist."

Priya was quiet for a long moment. "You're not wrong," she said. "But I think the problem already exists. It just hasn't been named yet."

Ananya nodded slowly. She looked at the window, at the evening campus outside. "I don't want to hurt him."

"I know."

"He's been so — he's just always been there. And I've been grateful. I genuinely have."

"I know, Anu."

"But gratitude isn't the same as love."

"No," Priya said. "It isn't."

They stayed there for a while longer. Then Priya picked up her highlighter and said she should go study, and Ananya said okay, and they said goodnight.

Ananya sat in her room for a long time after that. She thought about how to handle something that hadn't been explicitly said but was somehow completely known. She thought about kindness and honesty and whether they could both exist at the same time in this particular situation.

She decided to wait. To let the exams pass. To see if things settled. She told herself that was the reasonable choice, not the coward's choice.

She was half right, and she would wonder later which half.

"She knew. She had always known, in the way you know something you've been standing too close to — not blurry

because it isn't there, but because it fills everything."

— CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Wrong Kind of Love

There is a kind of love that doesn't know what it is. It starts as caring. It grows into devotion. And somewhere in the growing, it stops asking what the other person wants and starts asking only what it needs. It still calls itself love. It still uses the vocabulary of love. But it has changed, quietly, into something that puts its own ache at the center.

Dhruv didn't know this was happening. He thought he was still only giving. He thought his love was still the generous, unclaiming kind. He didn't see that it had started to ask for things without asking — that his presence had become a pressure, gentle but constant, the pressure of someone standing very close to you and breathing and breathing and waiting for you to notice that they are there.

There were signs, if he had been able to see them.

When Ananya mentioned plans with other people, he would respond with a smile that was one degree too small, a silence that was one second too long. When she talked about boys in her class or boys she'd met at other events, something in him stiffened. It wasn't obvious. It wasn't dramatic. But it was there — a tightening, a slight rearrangement of his features, a pause before he said "that sounds nice."

She was too kind to call it out. But she felt it. The way you feel a shift in temperature, you don't see it but your skin knows.

He mentioned her efforts less kindly now. Not cruelly — he was incapable of cruelty — but with a slight edge that hadn't been there before. *I thought we were meeting today*, where before he would have just said *are you coming today?* *I was waiting*, where before there would have been no mention of the waiting at all.

He sent messages more frequently. Not obsessively, not alarmingly, but slightly more often than was comfortable. She would reply and he would reply immediately, and then she would take a while to reply to that, and he would notice the time between her reply and his and then the time between his and her next reply, and the gap would register somewhere in the score he was still keeping.

One evening, she was studying at a cafe near the hostel with a boy from her Economics elective — someone she'd mentioned before, a classmate named Rahul who was also applying for MBA programs and with whom she had started exchanging notes. Dhruv happened to see them through the glass as he passed the cafe. He stopped. Rahul was making her laugh — she was leaning slightly forward over her textbook, head tilted, laughing at something. The same laugh he knew. The full one.

He walked past the cafe without going in. He walked three blocks further than he needed to, took the long way home, and arrived fifteen minutes later than he would have.

That night he texted her: *How was studying?*

She replied: *Good! Made a lot of progress. Finally understand comparative advantage.*

He replied: *Who were you studying with?*

A pause. Then: *Rahul from my elective. Why?*

He stared at his phone. He typed: *Just wondering. I thought you said you'd be at the hostel.*

Another pause, longer. *I didn't say that. I said I was studying. Dhruv, is something wrong?*

No. It's fine. Goodnight.

She replied: *Goodnight.*

But the full stop had a different quality than usual. He felt it.

He put the phone down. He lay on his bed in the dark. He thought about what he was doing, tried to see himself clearly from outside, the way you try to look in a mirror that's slightly fogged. He didn't like what he half-saw there.

He was watching her. He was tracking her. He was registering her laughs and her plans and who she spent time with and whether she mentioned it to him. He was doing it quietly, without accusation, but he was doing it. And some part of him — the part that had always been honest when it mattered — knew that this was wrong. Not angry-wrong or dangerous-wrong. Just: not the right way to love someone. Not the love he wanted to give. Not the version of himself he wanted to be.

But he didn't know how to stop. He didn't know how to take the feeling and make it smaller again. He didn't know how to put the stone back at the bottom of the pond, quiet and still, now that the water was moving.

He didn't sleep well that night. He hadn't been sleeping well for weeks.

In the morning, Ananya texted him before class: *Hi. Same library as usual after 3?*

He replied: *Yes.*

She was there at 3:10. She sat across from him and opened her notes and studied. He studied. After an hour, she looked up and said, "Are you sure you're okay? You've seemed off lately."

"I'm fine," he said. "Exam stress."

She nodded. She went back to her notes. She was giving him the benefit of the doubt. She always gave people the benefit of the doubt. It was one of the things he loved about her.

He looked at her across the table. He thought: *I need to get out of whatever I'm in. I need to come back to myself. I need to stop counting and start just — being.*

He meant it, when he thought it. He tried, in the weeks that followed, to go back to being only what he had always been. He tried to stop noting the gaps between messages, to stop stiffening at other names. He tried.

Some days he managed. Some days he didn't.

And the damage was not in any single moment. It was in the accumulation. The small repeated tightenings, the slight edges in the silences, the counting. She felt them, even when she didn't name them. You can't unsee something you've already started to see.

By the time the exams started, something had shifted between them. Not broken — not yet. But shifted. The way a door shifts when the wood expands: it still opens. But it requires slightly more effort now. You notice the difference every time.

"He thought he was loving her. He was — but in the wrong direction. Love that turns inward, that starts asking instead of giving, is still love. Just the kind that costs more than it was meant to."

— CHAPTER NINETEEN

PART FIVE

Distance

Shorter Messages

The final exams lasted two weeks. During that time, they studied — separately, mostly. She had her own rhythm and he had his, and the overlap that had always been comfortable became something that required coordination, and coordination required energy, and energy was in short supply at exam time.

Her messages became shorter.

This was the first thing he noticed, and he noticed it in the way you notice the lowering of temperature — not as a single moment but as a cumulative thing, where one day you realize you're cold and you can't say exactly when it happened.

Her messages had always been easy, meandering, the way she talked — one thing leading into another, sometimes with non sequiturs that he had come to recognize as a feature of how her mind worked. Now they were specific. Question, answer. Update, acknowledged. Logistics, confirmed. The texture of them had changed. Something conversational had been replaced with something functional.

He didn't say anything about it. He told himself it was exams. Everyone was busy. Shorter messages were normal.

But the late-night calls had also stopped. They had tapered off first — once a week instead of four times, then once every two weeks — and now they didn't happen. He noticed the spaces in the evenings where they used to

happen. He didn't call her. He was not going to call her and then feel like he was pulling at something.

The exams finished in April. The batch emerged, blinking and slightly hollow, into the ordinary daylight of post-exam campus, which felt both familiar and already different, charged with the knowledge that this was almost done.

He texted her: *Finally done. How was Paper 5?*

She replied: *Okay. Could have been better. You?*

Fine. Canteen tomorrow?

A pause longer than he expected. *I have some errands tomorrow. Maybe Thursday?*

Sure.

Thursday came. They met at the canteen. It was their first proper lunch in almost three weeks. She was warm, friendly, normal — asking about the exam, telling him about her MBA application status (she had heard back from two colleges, one rejection, one interview call). He listened and asked the right questions. They ate and talked.

But something was different. He couldn't name it precisely. It was like listening to a song you know very well and realizing one instrument has been removed — you can't identify which one immediately, but the absence is there, changing the sound.

She was present, but slightly less there than she used to be. Attentive, but with something reserved. The ease that had defined them from the

beginning was still mostly intact, but there were moments in the conversation where he felt it — a small pause, a slight choice of words, an almost-imperceptible awareness of something between them that she was navigating around.

She was being careful.

She had always been genuine and direct, and she still was. But she was choosing what to say and what not to say with slightly more deliberateness than before. She had seen something in the last few months — in the library, in the texts — and she was being careful.

He understood it, and it was the worst kind of understanding.

Because it confirmed what he had suspected but hadn't wanted to name: that something had changed, and that he had changed it, and that all his efforts to undo it had only drawn attention to the fact that there was something to undo.

They finished lunch. She said she had to go — she had a call with the MBA institute. He said good luck. She thanked him. They walked to the canteen door together and she went one way and he went the other.

He stood on the campus path for a moment, not moving.

The sun was warm. Students were walking in all directions. A crow was sitting on the notice board railing, utterly indifferent to everything. The broken fountain was, as always, broken.

He thought: we used to be easy.

He thought: I made it not easy.

He walked to his class. He sat down. He took out his notes. He studied, because studying was the one thing he knew how to do when everything else was beyond his control.

"The distance between them didn't arrive all at once. It grew one unanswered pause at a time, one shorter message, one careful word — until the space between them had its own weather."

— CHAPTER TWENTY

The Chair Beside Her

In May, someone else sat in the orange chair. It was a Wednesday, and Dhruv arrived at the canteen at the usual time and found the usual table — table seven — occupied by Ananya and three others from her friend group, including Priya, Sneha, and a boy he'd seen before but didn't know well. The orange chair had been pulled to make space for a fifth, and the boy was sitting in it, talking, animated. Ananya was laughing at something he said.

Dhruv stood at the entrance for a moment.

She hadn't texted him that morning. He hadn't texted her either. It had been a day where they hadn't coordinated, and on such days they each made their own plans. He knew this. He had always known this.

He went to the counter and ordered his rice and dal and found a different table — a small one near the window on the right side, where he usually sat when she wasn't there. He ate. He read his notes. He did not look at table seven.

Except he did, once. Just once.

She was still laughing at something. The same laugh. The full one. The boy — he was tall, broad-shouldered, had an easy way of talking that suggested a person for whom rooms came naturally, who never stood outside them wondering how to enter. He was gesturing with his hands. She was listening

with the slightly forward lean that Dhruv knew meant she was genuinely interested.

He looked back at his notes.

He ate the rest of his lunch.

He left the canteen without speaking to her.

She texted him that evening: *Sorry I missed you at lunch today. You weren't in the canteen?*

He stared at the message. He thought about what to say. He typed: *I was there. You had plans.*

She replied quickly: *I didn't know you were coming. You could have joined.*

It's fine.

A pause. *You sound off. Is everything okay?*

Yes. Just tired. Goodnight.

Goodnight, Dhruv.

He put the phone down. He went to his desk. He opened a book he wasn't going to read and stared at the page for a while and thought about the orange chair and the ease with which the other person had occupied it, and about the way she had leaned forward to listen to someone who wasn't him, and about all the ways he had told himself that being important to her was enough, and how that had been not entirely true for a long time.

He thought about what Priya had said, months ago now: *I just don't want either of you to get hurt.*

He thought: too late for me, Priya.

He thought: but she should be fine. She should stay fine. That's the point. That's been the whole point. I don't want her to feel what I feel. I don't want any of this to touch her.

And then he thought, with a honesty that surprised him even in its arrival: *but some of it already has, hasn't it? Some of what I've been carrying has already seeped through. She can feel the weight of it, even if I never named it. She's been careful around me. She's been protecting herself. And that means I've already made her feel like she needs to be protected.*

He closed the book. He turned off his light. He lay in the dark and thought about all of this for a long time.

He loved her. He would always love her in some form. That wasn't going to change just because he wished it would. But he had let the love become something else — something that pressed, something that watched, something that kept score — and he had let it happen because naming it honestly would have meant losing her as a friend, and losing her as a friend felt like losing too much.

But trying to keep the friendship exactly as it was, without addressing what was underneath, was costing her something too. He was only just beginning to see it.

He fell asleep. He dreamed nothing he remembered.

In the morning, the sun was ordinary and the day was ordinary, and he woke up and made tea and went to class, and things continued.

But something had clarified, very quietly, in the dark. He didn't know what to do with the clarity yet. He didn't know if he could do anything with it. But it was there, clean and painful and his.

"Someone else sat in his chair and the world didn't end. He had been afraid, for two years, that this is what would undo him. He was right, and he was wrong: it didn't end the world. Just his."

— CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Silence Is an Answer

There is a specific silence that arrives after a long period of almost-communication. It isn't angry. It isn't chosen. It simply settles in the place where there used to be easy words, and once it's there, you realize how much of what you had before was held together by words — and how much of the silence is just the truth of what was always underneath.

In June, the calls stopped completely. Not because either of them decided to stop — they just didn't start again. The pattern that had been broken by exams never reassembled itself. She didn't call. He didn't call. They texted sometimes, less than before.

In person, they were still — mostly — themselves. College was still happening, for a few more months. There were classes, though fewer, electives, placement preparations, department events. They still sat near each other in class. They still sometimes walked to the canteen together. On the surface, things looked the same.

But she no longer asked him to save the orange chair. And he no longer showed up early enough to save it.

And the late-night questions she used to bring to him — the exam questions, the life questions, the grandmother's-house conversations — she took somewhere else now. Or she kept them to herself. Either way, they didn't reach him.

He felt the absence of them the way you feel the absence of a sound you had been hearing so long you thought it was silence — you don't notice it until the silence has a different texture. He felt it and he didn't mention it and she didn't mention it, and they were both, in their own ways, being careful.

Priya said to him once, in passing, with the directness she had always shown him: "You've both gone quiet."

"We're both busy," he said.

"Sure," she said. In a tone that meant: *I know that's not all of it.*

Kavya noticed too. She mentioned it to Sameer, who mentioned it to Dhruv, sideways, over chai: "You and Ananya okay? You seem less —" he searched for the word. "Less you."

"We're fine," Dhruv said.

"You haven't had lunch together in like three weeks."

"She's been busy. I've been busy."

Sameer looked at him for a moment with more discernment than he usually gave him credit for. Then he said, "Okay," and let it go.

The truth was that there was nothing dramatic to report. There had been no argument, no confrontation, no scene. Just the gradual recession of something that had been close. Like the tide going out — you can't see it moving, but at some point the water is further than you expected, and the beach you remembered as narrow is suddenly wide and exposed and a little cold.

He missed her. He missed the specific version of her that he'd had — not a romantic version, just the close one. The library one. The late-night-call one. The orange-chair one. He missed those without knowing how to get them back, because getting them back would require acknowledging why they had gone, and acknowledging that would require a conversation he wasn't sure either of them was ready for.

She was, in some ways, protecting herself. He understood that now. She had felt the shape of what he was carrying even before she had named it, and she had instinctively created a little distance — not cruelly, not deliberately, but the way you step slightly back from something that is hotter than you expected. It wasn't a withdrawal from him. It was a protection from the weight.

And he, in turn, had tried to give her the distance because he was ashamed of the weight he had put there. He had pulled back from the counting, from the watching, from the slight edges in his messages. He was trying to go back to what he had been. He didn't know if it was possible. You can't put water back after it's already evaporated.

In July, she messaged him with something that felt like the old way. It was a picture of a chai cup at some cafe near the hostel, with a message underneath: *Found a place that makes chai exactly one sugar without me having to ask. Thought you'd appreciate the precision.*

He stared at the message for a long time. He felt something move in his chest — the small bird, still there, still on the branch, stirring.

He replied: *Send me the address. For my own research.*

She sent a laughing emoji and then the address.

It was the lightest exchange they'd had in months. It didn't fix anything. But it was something — a small green shoot in a lot of dry ground.

He saved the address in his phone. He didn't go there for weeks. But he saved it.

"Silence between two people who used to have so much to say is not empty. It is full — of everything they are no longer saying, and everything that happened to make them stop."

— CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

He Tried Everything

He tried everything.

He tried being more present and he tried being less present. He tried texting more and texting less. He tried being at the canteen at the old time and then not being at the canteen at all. He tried going back to the library on Thursday afternoons, and she was there one time, and they studied together, and it was almost the old way, and he thought: this is it, we're finding it again. And then the next Thursday she wasn't there, and the Thursday after that was a holiday, and the rhythm didn't reassemble.

He went to the cafe that had the chai she had recommended. He sent her a picture of it with the caption: *Research confirmed. One sugar. Precise.* She replied with three laughing emojis and then nothing after. He stared at the three laughing emojis and told himself they were enough. They weren't enough.

He suggested they study for the placement aptitude tests together, like they'd always prepared for exams together. She said she'd already started a study group with Priya and two others. She said he could join if he wanted. He said he'd think about it. He didn't join. He studied alone and remembered all the other times he'd sat across from her at the window table and explained demand curves while she taught them back to him.

He wrote things in the notebook that he kept for himself — not the academic ones, the personal one, dark blue, like the one he'd given her, with

unlined pages. He had been writing in it for years but mostly small things, observations, fragments. Now he wrote more. He wrote what he couldn't say. He wrote about patience and its limits. He wrote about what it felt like to love someone you couldn't tell and whether the loving was his to bear or something she should know about.

He came to no conclusions. The notebook accumulated pages that were honest and unresolved, and that was the truest thing about them.

Kavya, who had a low threshold for watching people suffer unnecessarily, sat beside him one afternoon in September and said: "Dhruv. Are you in love with Ananya?"

He looked at her.

She looked back with the frankness of someone who has been watching something for too long and has decided to skip the approach and go straight to the point.

"Yes," he said.

"Does she know?"

"Not explicitly."

"Does she know implicitly?"

He thought about it. "I think she might."

"And you're not going to tell her."

"She doesn't feel that way about me, Kavya."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes."

She nodded slowly, absorbing this. "Then you're suffering for nothing. Or for something that can't change."

"It's not nothing. I'm just —" he paused. "I don't know how to feel differently. It's not something I turned on. I can't turn it off."

"I know." Her voice was gentler now. "But you're making yourself miserable. And — Dhruv, I say this as your friend — some of it is landing on her. She feels the weight of it, even if you think you're hiding it."

He was quiet.

"Have you thought about telling her? Just — saying it? Even if nothing changes. Just saying it so it's out instead of in?"

"If I tell her, I lose her as a friend."

"You might be losing her anyway," Kavya said, not unkindly. "Slowly. The way you're losing things now."

He looked at her. She was right, and he knew it, and it was the kind of knowing that sits in your chest like a stone — the cold, settled kind that doesn't move when you try to move it.

"I'll think about it," he said.

"Okay." She patted his arm, once, the way his sister would have. "I'm here. For whatever you figure out."

He thought about it. He thought about it all of that week and into the next. He rehearsed words in his head while he was studying and walking and eating and lying awake. He ran through scenarios: how she would respond, what he would say, what she would say, how they would manage afterward.

Every scenario he ran had the same ending. He said it. She listened. She was kind. She said she didn't feel that way, and she was sorry, and she hoped they could still be friends. And he said of course, and they tried, and something between them broke completely and quietly and finally, and the remainder of their friendship was a careful, polite monument to what it had been before.

He didn't want that. He was afraid of that most of all — not the rejection, but the careful politeness afterward, the managed distance, the loss of all the natural things: the way she said his name, the ease of the silences, the specific texture of being known by her.

So he didn't tell her. He kept it inside where it had always been, and he kept trying everything, and nothing worked, and the distance held.

The third year continued. The graduation date got closer. Everything felt like both too much time and not enough, which is the particular mathematics of an ending that you can see from a distance but cannot stop.

"He tried everything except the one thing that might have helped: telling the truth. But the truth, he feared, was the last thing between them, and speaking it would dissolve even that."

PART SIX

Her

A Different Kind of Smile

He noticed the change in October. Not in a dramatic way. Not in a single moment. It was like watching water come to a boil — for a long time nothing happens, and then everything happens at once. In this case, the gradual accumulation of small signs that he had been observing, not quite consciously, for weeks.

She smiled at her phone more often. She texted during lunch — not constantly, but enough for him to notice, because she had always been the type to put her phone away at meals, a habit she'd mentioned being particular about. She started wearing earrings more frequently. Small ones, but there. She seemed — lighter. Not happier in the obvious way, not giddy or changed. Just lighter. Like something that had been sitting on her had been gently removed.

He noticed that she mentioned a name he hadn't heard before: Arjun. First in passing — *Arjun said something interesting about this*, dropping into a conversation about MBA interview preparation. Then more frequently. Not a lot. Not more than anyone else's name. But present, in the way that a new thing is present when it's started to become part of the landscape.

He didn't ask about Arjun immediately. He filed the name, the way he filed everything. He waited.

Then one afternoon they were at the cafe — the first time in months they had gone together, just the two of them, which had felt like an opening

when she suggested it. She had her hazelnut coffee. He had plain. The sun came through the windows and the cafe was warm and mostly quiet.

She was telling him about a mock interview she'd done for her MBA applications, and she was in the middle of a sentence when she laughed — not at what she was saying, at something on her phone, which she'd glanced at for a second.

He watched her laugh.

It was the real laugh. The full one. But — different. Not in quality. The same reach, the same warmth. Different in where it came from. It came from something outside this room, something he wasn't part of, and there was a new thing in it — a lightness that was specifically private, that didn't quite become public even when she looked up and smiled at him and said "sorry, that was Arjun."

He kept his face still. He was good at keeping his face still. He said, "Your friend from the MBA prep?"

"Yes. He sent a meme about interview anxiety. Very accurate meme." She put her phone down. "He's funny. Different funny from — well, different kind of humor."

"Different from what?"

"Just different. You know how people have different types of humor? He's more —" she searched for the word. "Playful. Quick."

He nodded. He drank his coffee. He said, "How long have you known him?"

"A few months. He's doing his final year at a different college. We met at an MBA workshop. He's applying to a lot of the same programs." She wrapped her hands around her cup, the way she always did with warm things. "He's good. He's — I like talking to him."

She said it simply. *I like talking to him*. Three words that were nothing and everything at the same time.

Dhruv looked at his coffee. He thought about all the times he had thought: *I like talking to her*. He thought about how those same words carried different weight depending on who said them and to whom.

"That's good," he said. And he meant it, or some part of him meant it, the part that still wanted her to be well even when being well meant something that hurt him.

"He makes me — laugh," she said, and then seemed slightly surprised by her own honesty, and looked at her cup.

He noticed that pause. That slight surprise. The way you're surprised when you say something out loud that you hadn't fully admitted to yourself yet. He noticed it and registered it and held it.

"Good," he said again. His voice was steady. He was proud of that.

She looked up at him. "You're okay?"

"I'm fine. Tell me about the MBA prep. How many colleges are you up to now?"

She shifted back to the subject easily. She talked about it and he listened and asked the right questions. He did not look at her phone when it lit up

once with a notification.

He drank his coffee. He was present. He was fine.

He was not fine, but he was in the room, and in the room he was fine, and when the afternoon ended and they walked to the gate and went their separate ways, he held himself together all the way home.

In his room, he sat at his desk with his notebook and he wrote: *October 12th. She laughed at something on her phone. I think she's happy about someone. I think it isn't me. I knew it wasn't going to be me. But knowing and seeing are different weights.*

He closed the notebook. He looked at the wall. He was twenty-one years old and the person he loved was falling for someone else and there was nothing in the universe he could do about it.

He did nothing. He made tea. He did his assignment. He went to bed.

He did not sleep well.

"She laughed at her phone and didn't know he was watching. He watched and didn't show it. That was the whole story — what they hid from each other, and what it cost."

— CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Arjun

Dhruv met Arjun in November. It happened at a department event — a talk by a visiting professor on career paths in finance, attended by students from several colleges. Ananya had mentioned she was going. Dhruv had also registered. He hadn't known, until he arrived, that they would end up in the same row.

She was already seated when he came in. Beside her was someone he recognized from the description without needing one: tall, easy posture, the kind of relaxed confidence that isn't performed, a laugh that arrived quickly and genuinely when the girl on his other side said something. He was wearing a plain white shirt and had a notebook with a pen clipped to it — the practical, unshowy notebook of someone who actually uses it.

She looked up and saw Dhruv and waved. "Dhruv! Come sit, there's space." She gestured to the seat beside Arjun.

He walked over. He sat down. Ananya said, "Dhruv, this is Arjun. Arjun, Dhruv — my closest friend from college."

My closest friend from college. He heard it. He stored it. He turned to Arjun and extended his hand.

Arjun shook it. His handshake was firm and brief. He said, "Dhruv — she talks about you." His voice was direct, without the artificial warmth of someone performing friendliness. Just honest.

"Good things, I hope," Dhruv said. The standard answer. He smiled.

"Mostly good." Arjun grinned. "She says you're the best person she knows for cutting through unnecessary complexity. That you take something complicated and find the actual core of it."

Dhruv looked at Ananya. She raised her eyebrows — *don't blame me, that's what I said*.

"She's exaggerating," he said.

"She doesn't seem like someone who exaggerates," Arjun said, simply.

She was sitting between them, looking at the front of the room as the event organizers prepared the stage, with an expression that was slightly careful — aware of the situation, aware of him, aware of what this might look like from the outside. She was being very natural. She was very natural. That was the thing about her — she was real. She didn't perform. Even now, in a moment that had some complexity to it, she was just herself.

He looked at Arjun when Ananya looked away. He tried to find something not to like. He tried, honestly. Not out of malice, but out of the desperate human instinct to find a flaw in the thing that was taking something from you.

He couldn't find one.

Arjun was considerate. He leaned over to help someone find the right page in the handout. When the professor asked a question, he answered thoughtfully, not to show off but because he had actually thought about it. During a break, he went to get water and came back with three cups instead of one. He laughed easily and without cruelty. When Ananya said

something, he listened with his full attention — and not the performed attention of someone being a good listener, but the real kind, the kind that produces the right response because it actually registered what was said.

He was good. He was genuinely good.

Dhruv hated and understood this simultaneously, in a ratio that shifted from one to the other and back throughout the afternoon.

On the walk out after the event, the three of them walked together for a while. Arjun talked about an internship he had done that was relevant to the day's topic. Dhruv asked questions — real questions, because he was interested despite everything. Ananya walked between them and contributed and laughed and was herself.

At the junction where their routes diverged, Arjun said, "Dhruv, it was good to meet you. We should all get chai sometime."

"Yes," Dhruv said. He meant it, or he tried to.

Arjun left. Ananya and Dhruv walked a little further before her bus stop, in a silence that had a different weight than their usual silences.

She said, "He's good, right?"

"Yes," Dhruv said. And then, because he was capable of honesty when it mattered: "He's very good."

She nodded. She was looking at the ground. Her shoulders had something in them — not tension, something softer than that. Something like admission.

He understood, in that moment, with the clarity of a sentence that has finally been completed, what was happening. What was already happening. What he had known for weeks but had not put into full words.

He said nothing. They reached her bus stop. She said goodbye and he said goodbye and they went their separate ways.

He walked home. The evening was cool. The streetlights were coming on one by one, the warm orange kind that turn everything slightly gold. He walked in the light of them and felt something settle in his chest that was the exact opposite of the lightness he'd felt when he'd given her the orange chair. A settling that was heavy and final and already, in some strange way, beginning to be something he could hold.

He thought: *He deserves her.*

He thought: *I knew it would be someone like him.*

He thought: *That doesn't make it easier. But it makes it fair.*

"He tried to find a flaw in Arjun and couldn't. That was the worst part — not the competition, but the absence of it. She had found someone genuinely good."

— CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

She Told Him

She told him on a Thursday.

They were at the library — the second window table, the right side, the place where so much of their story had happened. He'd been there first. She'd come in and sat across from him and they'd spent an hour studying in the quiet that had become, in the past few months, slightly more careful than it used to be but still mostly good.

Then she closed her book. He looked up. She was looking at him with the expression she used when she had something to say that she was uncertain about — that careful measuring look, the one he knew was her calculating how much honesty the situation required.

"Can I tell you something?" she said.

"Yes."

She put her hands flat on the table. She looked at them. "I think I have feelings for Arjun." She looked up. "Real ones. Not just — I think I like him. I think it's becoming more than that."

He looked at her. He held himself very still.

She was watching him carefully. Not anxiously — she wasn't performing concern. But carefully, the way you watch someone when you know the

thing you're saying might land in a complicated way, and you want to see how it's landing.

He thought about what he felt. He could have named several things. He could have named all of them, given time. But what came out, after a moment that was longer than a normal moment but shorter than one that would have been obvious, was this: he smiled.

It was a real smile. Not full — he couldn't give it full, his face didn't have that in him right now — but real. Not performed, not strained. The smile of someone who has arrived at the answer to a question they had been asking for a long time, and the answer is painful but it is also true, and true things, however painful, have their own kind of peace.

"That's good," he said.

She blinked. "Yeah?"

"He's good," Dhruv said. "I told you he was good. You should be with someone good."

She held his gaze for a moment. There was something in her expression — complex, reading him. "You're sure you're okay?"

"I'm okay."

"Dhruv —"

"Ananya." He said her name, quietly, with all the steadiness he had. "I'm happy for you."

She looked at him for another long moment. Then she nodded. Something shifted in her — the slight tension in her shoulders went, and she exhaled, not dramatically but audibly, the exhale of someone who had been holding something in and has been allowed to set it down.

"I wasn't sure how to tell you," she said. "I didn't know — I wasn't sure what —" she stopped. Tried again. "You're my closest person here. I wanted you to know."

"I know," he said. "I'm glad you told me."

"He asked if I wanted to meet for dinner last week," she said, more quietly. "Officially. Like — not just study or an event. And I said yes."

"Good," he said.

She smiled. Not the complicated smile — the first one, the wide one, the one with the dimple. Genuine. "He's nervous. I'm nervous. It's very ridiculous."

"That's how it should be," he said. And he meant it. He meant that too.

She said, "Thank you for being —" she paused, seeming to search for the word and not quite finding it. "Thank you for being you."

He didn't trust his voice with a full sentence at that moment, so he just nodded. She seemed to understand that.

They went back to studying. The library was quiet around them. The garden was doing its late-afternoon thing outside the window, the light going long and gold. Dhruv looked at his notes. He read the same paragraph three times before it went in. He was fine. He was in the room and he was fine.

When the library began to close, they packed up and walked down the stairs together, and through the campus and to the gate, the same route they had walked a hundred times. At the gate, she gave him a quick hug — not their usual side-by-side goodbye, but an actual hug, brief but real, her arms around his shoulders for a second. He stood very still and let it happen.

"See you tomorrow?" she said when she stepped back.

"See you tomorrow."

She smiled and went right. He went left.

He walked two blocks. Three. Four. His chest felt like it had a hand around it, squeezing at irregular intervals. His vision was slightly blurred at the edges in a way that had nothing to do with the light, which was fine, which was ordinary evening light, not particularly bright, not particularly dim.

He stopped at a corner. He pressed his back against a wall — a building, a shop, he couldn't have said which. He breathed. In and out, carefully, the way you breathe when you're trying to prevent something and you don't know if it's going to work.

He stood there for a while. Not long. Not long enough for anyone passing to notice.

Then he straightened up. He picked up his bag. He walked the rest of the way home.

He didn't call anyone. He didn't text anyone. He made tea, as he always did when he came home. He sat at his desk. He opened his notebook — the dark blue one, the personal one — and he wrote for a long time. Not a letter to

her. Not anything dramatic. Just what was true, quietly, sentence by sentence, the only way he knew how to hold something.

He was there for a long time. By the time he stopped, the tea was cold and the room was dark and he had six pages and he was not better but he was lighter, the specific lightness of things that have been expressed instead of held.

He closed the notebook. He turned off the light. He lay in the dark.

He thought: *She's going to be happy.*

He thought: *I can hold that. That's enough.*

It wasn't quite enough. But it was closer to enough than he'd expected to get.

"He smiled when she told him. The smile was real. So was what was happening behind it. Both things were true at the same time, and he held them both, because that was all he could do."

— CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

After She Left the Room

In the days after that Thursday, Dhruv moved through the ordinary mechanics of his life with a precision that surprised him. He went to class. He ate meals. He answered messages. He helped Sameer understand a financial modeling concept. He agreed to Kavya's suggestion that the group go for dinner before graduation, and he showed up to that dinner on the right evening at the right place and was present for all of it.

People would not have known, from the outside, that anything was different.

Inside was different.

Inside, something had changed shape. Not disappeared — the love for her didn't disappear. He understood now that it wouldn't disappear, not completely, not soon. But it had changed from something that pressed outward, something urgent and needing an outlet, into something that was simply — there. Present but no longer demanding. The way an old injury becomes something you notice on certain movements rather than something that controls all your movements.

He had named it, finally. Not to her — to himself. To his notebook. He had written it down: *I love her. I have loved her since the second semester of the first year. She does not love me in that way. She is with someone who is good for her. And I want her to have what is good for her. Both of these things are true and both of them are mine to carry.*

That was the beginning of something, even though it felt mostly like an ending.

She was happy. He could see it. She was the same person — the same Ananya, same jokes, same hazelnut coffee, same way of explaining things, same laugh. But there was a quality in her now of someone whose energy was directed at something new and good. She mentioned Arjun occasionally — not constantly, not in a way that seemed designed to show off or make anything of it, just naturally, the way you mention someone when they're part of your life. *Arjun and I went to this place near his college, the biryani was actually very good. Arjun thinks I should just go directly for the Delhi institute instead of the one in Pune as backup.*

He listened. He responded. He was her friend.

He was going to stay being her friend, he had decided. Not because it didn't hurt — it did, variably, some days less than others. But because the friendship was real, and it was his, and losing it would lose the last of what they'd built together. And she had told him because he was her closest person. That was real. That was his to keep.

Kavya asked him once, in November, "How are you? Actually."

"Better," he said. And it was true. Not healed — better.

"She seems happy," Kavya said.

"She is." He said it simply, without the complicated pause that would have accompanied it two months ago.

Kavya looked at him. "You're doing well," she said, and she said it like a compliment, which it was.

"I'm trying," he said.

"Trying counts." She looked at him a moment longer. "For what it's worth — you're a good person, Dhruv. You've been a good friend to her. And I know it cost you."

He nodded. He didn't say anything to that. What was there to say to that?

"And — whatever comes next, you're going to be okay. You know that, right?"

"I'm starting to," he said.

It was almost true. It would be fully true, eventually. These things take time, and he was beginning to understand that taking time was not weakness — it was just the honest pace of real things. Real things didn't rush. Real things moved at the speed they needed to, and trying to force them faster only made them break differently.

He thought about all the ways he had tried to rush this — to manage it, to contain it, to prevent it from showing. He thought about how he had let the love become something pressuring, something score-keeping, something that had made her careful around him. He was not proud of that. He was not going to pretend he was.

But he was also not going to stay in that. He had made a mistake, the way people make mistakes when they are in pain and don't know a better way to handle it. The mistake didn't define him. The after was where the real work was. The after was where you found out who you actually were.

He was finding out. Carefully, unglamorously, one day at a time.

He was finding out that he could be glad for her without being over it. That he could be her friend without it being a performance. That the part of him that loved her could coexist with the part of him that was slowly learning to put his own life back together.

He could hold all of it.

He was learning to hold all of it.

"Heartbreak is not a single moment. It is a season — long, variable, with days of sun that do not quite warm you yet, and cold nights that are slightly less cold than before."

— CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

PART SEVEN

Farewell

Last Semester

The last semester had its own texture, distinct from everything that had come before.

The coursework was lighter — most of the major subjects were done, and what remained were electives, a final project, and the lingering administrative work of finishing. The campus knew it was almost over, and this knowledge changed how people moved through it. More slowly. More deliberately. With the awareness of people who are, for the first time, looking at something in order to remember it rather than just to use it.

Dhruv noticed everything about Meghna College that he had not noticed when it was simply the background of his days.

He noticed the specific sound the canteen made at 1:15 — a particular density of voices and movement and the metallic clatter of serving trays that was recognizable even from the corridor. He noticed the exact slant of the winter light through the library windows, which was different from the autumn light and different again from the monsoon light. He noticed that the broken fountain in the garden had, at some point in the third year, been replaced by a bench that someone had painted yellow, and the yellow was fading now, and somehow that was more charming than the fountain had ever been.

He noticed table seven in the canteen, which he still went to sometimes, alone or with Sameer, and which didn't have the same meaning it had

carried for the first two years but was still familiar the way a well-worn chair is familiar — not new, not full of promise, just known.

He sat at table seven with Ananya twice in the last semester. Both times were easy and warm, with the particular ease of people who have been through something and come out the other side still able to eat lunch together. They talked about their futures — she had been accepted at an MBA program in Pune, her first choice. He had decided on a CA — he'd been working through the foundation exams, quietly, alongside his final year, and had found in the process that it was the right thing, not spectacular but right, the way the best decisions often are.

She was pleased when he told her. "That suits you," she said. "The thoroughness of it. You'll be very good at it."

"Or I'll be exhausted by it."

"Both can be true," she said.

He smiled. "Both are already true."

She talked about Arjun. He listened. Arjun had also gotten into an MBA program — different city, which meant a distance they were figuring out together, which was its own conversation, its own uncertainty. She said this with a slightly different energy, not worried exactly, more — real. The way someone speaks about something they've decided to handle rather than something they're afraid of.

"You'll figure it out," he said.

"Probably," she agreed.

"You always do. Eventually."

She looked at him. "You borrowed my own line."

"It's a good line."

She smiled. He smiled. The canteen was full around them, familiar and loud, and there were three months left of this particular version of their lives.

The last semester also had goodbye events, which started early and overlapped. Farewell parties for each batch, organized by the junior batches with the particular efficiency of people who know what a farewell should look like because they've attended them. A department dinner that was more formal than expected. An informal gathering in the open garden area on a Friday evening that was definitely not sanctioned by college administration but was attended by about seventy people and ended only when the watchman very patiently insisted.

Dhruv went to most of them. He was not a person who sought out social events, but he understood that these were the last ones, and the last ones had a different math. You went even when you didn't need to. You showed up because showing up was the acknowledgment that it had mattered.

It had mattered. All of it. The three years, the people, the campus, the broken fountain and the yellow bench, the canteen and the library and the café with the hazelnut coffee. Even the parts that had hurt. Especially those, maybe. Pain meant something real had happened. He wasn't going to walk away from the pain without also keeping the real thing that had caused it.

He was twenty-one years old and the last chapter of this specific life was being written, and he was trying to be present for it.

"In the last semester, he finally started to see the college clearly — not as a backdrop, but as a thing in itself, worthy of being watched before it was gone."

— CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Final Photograph

The farewell was in April. A Saturday. The auditorium had been decorated — fairy lights, a backdrop with the batch year, tables laid out with snacks and the particular chaos of an event organized by students who had put genuine effort into it and were also slightly exhausted.

The batch gathered in small clusters, the way they always did, but the clusters were different now — people who had spent three years in the same room but different orbits were mixing, bridging, finding each other before the dispersal. Dhruv stood with Sameer and Vivek for a while, then with Kavya and two girls from Section B he'd gotten to know later in the year. He moved through the room at his own pace — not lonely, not performing, just there.

Ananya was there with Priya and Riya and a few others. She had worn something blue — a blue salwar — and she had earrings on, the small silver ones she wore for occasions. She looked exactly like herself, which was the most accurate and honest thing he could say: she hadn't changed for this, hadn't become more or less anything. She was just exactly herself.

They found each other at some point in the evening. Not by arrangement — just by the natural gravitational drift of two people in a room who know each other well enough that their paths eventually converge.

"Hi," she said.

"Hi." He looked at her. "You look nice."

"Thank you." She looked at him. "You got a haircut."

"Two weeks ago."

"It's good." She glanced around the auditorium. "Is this strange to you? This feels very strange."

"Yes."

"Three years and then — this. One evening and then it's over." She held her glass — juice, he noticed, she rarely drank — and looked at the room. "I feel like I should be saying something important. But I can't think of what."

"I don't think important things need to be said tonight specifically," he said. "They've already been said. Or done. Over three years."

She looked at him. "That's true." A pause. "I think about the first day of orientation sometimes. That room. The two of us not knowing anyone."

"You'd gone to the wrong building first."

She laughed. "The map on the website was terrible. I stand by that."

"It was terrible," he agreed.

They stood together for a moment, holding that. Then Sameer appeared with a camera and said, "Everybody who matters — photo, now, before anyone leaves." And he gathered the group — Dhruv, Ananya, Kavya, Vivek, Priya, Sneha, two others — and arranged them with the loose authority of someone who has strong opinions about photographs and no patience for stragglers.

Dhruv ended up beside Ananya. Not by design — Sameer put them there, and Vivek was on the other side, and someone put an arm around someone and the photo happened. He was standing close to her, their arms touching slightly, her blue against his grey.

Sameer counted to three. The flash happened. Somebody blinked. Sameer said they'd do it again. The second one was better, apparently. Then Sameer said the third one was the one, the real one, and they all leaned in slightly and the third flash went.

After, Ananya showed him the photo on Sameer's phone. The third one. There they were — eight of them, slightly compressed, the auditorium in the background, all looking at the camera except Vivek, who was looking at something slightly to the left.

They both looked happy in the photograph. They both looked like themselves. Standing close, the way they'd always stood, the way it had always been.

"Good one," she said.

"Yes," he said.

She handed the phone back to Sameer. She looked at Dhruv one more time with an expression that was complete — not sad, not relieved, not performing anything. Just present. Just real. "Three years, Dhruv."

"Three years," he said.

"I'm glad it was with you. This part. Whatever part this was."

He held that. He let it settle into the place where all the things she'd ever said to him were stored — her name in his margins, the note she'd left in his textbook, the way she'd told him he was good at knowing what people needed, the birthday with the blue notebook, the smile across the room in Mahabaleshwar, all of it.

"Me too," he said. Quietly. Completely.

She nodded once. Then someone called her name from across the room, and she looked over, and then back at him with a quick smile that was apology and warmth at once, and she went.

He watched her go. He held his glass. The fairy lights made everything slightly gold, the way good lighting always makes things slightly better than they are.

He thought: *This is the last time this exact thing will happen.*

He thought: *I'm glad I was here for it.*

Both were true. Both were his.

"In the photograph, they are both smiling. That is the most honest record of what they were — two people who were, for a time, exactly where they should have been, even if it was never quite what one of them hoped."

Graduation Day

Graduation was in May. The auditorium was transformed again — more formally this time, a stage with a blue curtain, rows of chairs, parents and family in the back sections, the batch in academic gowns that nobody quite knew how to wear correctly and that made everyone simultaneously uncomfortable and strangely equal.

Dhruv's mother cried when she helped him pin the gown properly. His father pretended not to notice her crying, which was his version of being supportive. They took a photograph in the college garden, and his father said "good job" in the clipped, sincere way he said everything, and his mother said "I'm so proud of you" and meant it so completely that the sentence needed no decoration.

He hugged them both, which was unusual for him — he wasn't demonstrative that way. But it felt right. It felt like the right thing to hold onto at a moment when everything else was becoming past tense.

The ceremony was long. Sixty-two names called out. Each one walked to the stage and shook the principal's hand and received the degree certificate and walked back. Some people cheered. Some people cried. Some people did both simultaneously, which was perhaps the most honest response to the occasion.

Ananya's name was called early — the roll numbers went in sequence, and hers came before his. He watched her walk up — straight-backed, her

dupatta today a deep red, her gown making her look slightly shorter than she was. She shook the principal's hand. She took her certificate. She turned to go back, and for a second — just a second — she was facing the auditorium, and her eyes swept the seated rows, and they found him, and she smiled. The first smile, the wide one. And then she walked back to her seat.

He watched her go. He thought: *I've watched her walk away in so many different directions so many times. I have memorized the back of her head. I could describe it to you in the dark.*

His name was called forty minutes later. He walked to the stage. He shook the principal's hand. He received the certificate. He turned back to the auditorium, and from somewhere in the seated rows he heard a small, distinct cheer that was Kavya, because Kavya cheered for everyone with the same specific enthusiasm. He smiled and walked back.

After the ceremony, the campus became something it had never been in all three years: a kind of controlled chaos with gowns and photographs and parents and relief and grief and happiness all happening simultaneously in all directions.

He found his group. He took photographs with each of them. With Sameer, who was genuinely emotional and hid it by making more jokes than usual. With Vivek, who shook his hand and said "it was good to know you" with the simple sincerity that defined everything Vivek said. With Kavya, who hugged him for slightly longer than expected and said "call me sometimes, please, I mean it" with the urgency of someone who knew he wasn't good at that.

"I'll try," he said.

"That's not the right answer but I'll accept it," she said.

He found Ananya near the garden, with Priya and her parents. She was showing her parents something on her phone — probably the photograph from the farewell. Her father had the same way of holding himself that she did, the same stillness before speaking. Her mother was talking quickly, affectionately, the way her mother would.

He waited at a slight distance. She saw him and excused herself from her parents and came over.

"Dhruv." She was holding her certificate and her degree. Her gown was coming slightly loose on one shoulder. She looked exhausted in the good way of someone who has finished a very long and important thing.

"Congratulations," he said.

"You too." She looked at his certificate. "B.Com. Done."

"B.Com. Done."

She looked at him for a moment. "I leave for Pune in July. The MBA program starts in August."

"I know. You'll do well."

"Probably." She smiled, small. "I'll stay in touch. That's not just something people say. I mean it."

"I know you mean it," he said.

She nodded. Then she did something he hadn't expected: she put her arms around him, a proper hug, not the brief one from the farewell but a real one,

her arms around his shoulders and her head slightly bowed. He stood very still for a moment, and then he put his arms around her too, careful and present and honest for the first time about what this was: goodbye. Not forever, maybe. But goodbye to this. To all of this.

She stepped back. Her eyes were slightly bright. She blinked once, quickly. "Take care of yourself," she said.

"You too."

"I mean it. Don't just take care of everyone around you. Take care of yourself."

He looked at her. He thought: she knows. She has always known, in her own way, more than she ever said. She knew and she was kind about it and she said this now because it was the most honest and gentle thing she could give him.

"I will," he said.

She nodded once. Then her mother called her name from across the garden, and she turned to look, and she looked back at him with the expression he had catalogued as the third smile — the one that was doing work, that was holding something in, that was being brave about something. And then she walked back to her parents.

He watched her go.

Then he turned and walked to his own parents, who were waiting patiently near the yellow bench, his mother still slightly teary, his father checking something on his phone. He stood between them. His mother took his hand briefly. His father said they should go eat somewhere good to celebrate.

He said yes. He walked with them out of the campus, through the gate, past the neem tree at the corner where the bus stopped, into the ordinary city street where nothing had changed and everything was different.

He didn't look back. He had already memorized it. He didn't need to.

"He walked out of the gate without looking back. Not because it didn't matter. Because it mattered completely, and he had already memorized every part of it, and some things you carry better when you keep walking."

— CHAPTER THIRTY

PART EIGHT

After

Three Years Later

He was twenty-four when he saw her again. Not a planned meeting. He had been in Delhi for a CA exam module — staying for three days at a modest hotel near the exam center, eating whatever was close, studying in the evenings with the particular focused solitude of someone who has made peace with being on their own.

He was at a coffee shop on the third morning, waiting for a friend from his CA batch who was running twenty minutes late. He had ordered his coffee — plain, no flavor, no sugar, as always. He was reading something on his phone. The coffee shop was the kind that exists in every Indian city now: neutral, clean, slightly self-conscious, good enough.

The door opened. He looked up, as you do when a door opens.

She came in.

And beside her, Arjun.

They were in the middle of a conversation. She was making a point about something — he could tell from her posture, the slight forward lean, one hand gesturing. Arjun was listening and nodding with the full-attention quality he had noticed the first time they met. They looked — comfortable. The way people look when they have gotten through the uncertain first part and arrived at something settled and real.

She was exactly herself. Same Ananya, same way of holding herself, same energy. Slightly different hair — shorter now, though he wasn't sure when she'd cut it. Same earrings, the small silver ones. She was wearing something she might have worn in college — a kurta, dark green — and for a second the three years between then and now contracted, and he felt the old familiar weight shift in his chest.

Then it settled again. Differently than it used to. Quieter.

She looked around the cafe for a seat and found him.

The half-second of surprise on her face. Then recognition. Then warmth. And then — underneath it all, something that was maybe relief, or maybe just the complex gentleness of seeing someone from a particular chapter of your life, intact and well.

"Dhruv," she said.

"Hi," he said.

Arjun saw him too. Recognized him — he had a good memory, apparently, or she had spoken about him enough that Dhruv's face was familiar. He raised his hand: a simple, uncomplicated greeting.

Dhruv raised his hand back.

She came over to his table. He stood, the way you do. They hugged — brief, warm, real. She smelled like the same shampoo, something light. He let go.

"What are you doing in Delhi?" she asked.

"CA exams. Module 3."

"You're almost done?"

"One more year."

"That's wonderful." She meant it. "How is it going?"

"Hard. But going." He looked at her. "You? MBA was in Pune?"

"Yes, finished last year. I'm working here now — a consulting firm."

"You like it?"

"I love it," she said, simply. And he believed her. He could see it in the way she said it — not performing contentment but actually in it. "Delhi took some getting used to. But I'm here now."

He looked at Arjun, who was waiting at a polite distance. "He's here too."

"Yes. We're — he found a job here a few months ago." She said it without drama, without either hiding it or offering it as information that required a response. She said it the way she always said real things: as a fact that was simply part of her life.

"Good," Dhruv said.

She looked at him. That careful-reading look. "Are you —"

"I'm well," he said. And it was true. Not perfectly well, not dramatically well. Just genuinely, honestly, ordinarily well. "I'm working at a firm in Pune for the practical experience portion. Coming back in two days."

"Still in Pune."

"For now. We'll see what comes after."

She nodded. "You seem —" she looked for the word. "Settled."

"I think that's probably right."

She smiled. Not the complicated smile, not the work smile. The first one, the wide one. "I'm glad," she said. And she meant it, and he knew she meant it, because she was still exactly herself, three years later — someone who said what she meant and meant what she said.

His friend arrived then, apologizing loudly, dropping his bag on the chair across. Ananya said she should go find a seat before the place filled up. He said yes. She said it was very good to see him. He said the same, and meant it in the specific way of someone who has processed what they felt and come out the other side: not without the feeling, but past its sharpest edge.

She went to Arjun. He ordered his coffee. They sat a few tables away and talked, their voices part of the general background of the place, audible without being distinct. His friend talked about the exam and he listened and participated and was present.

He didn't look at her table again.

He didn't need to. He had already done all the looking, in all the years that had brought him here. He had looked enough. He had stored enough. He knew what she looked like. He knew who she was. She was well and she was herself and she was with someone who made her laugh the full laugh, and that was — that was good. That was the outcome that made sense. That was the one that was right.

When he left the coffee shop twenty minutes later, he passed their table. She looked up and gave him a quick, simple wave — the same small flag-raise from the first day of orientation, three years and more ago. He raised his hand back. He kept walking.

He stepped out into the Delhi morning, which was bright and slightly chaotic and completely indifferent to him, as cities always are. He stood on the street for a moment, his bag over one shoulder, his friend already heading toward the exam center.

He thought about the first day. The wrong bus stop, the orientation hall, the fourth row, the girl with the yellow dupatta who had a bag that attacked people.

He thought about the library and the canteen and the rain and the birthday and the festival and the trip and the calls and the distance and the letting go. All of it, the whole story, the complete arc of it, from the beginning through the ending and into this: a coffee shop in Delhi, a brief wave, and walking out into a morning that was his and only his.

He had loved her. He had loved her imperfectly — generously and then desperately and then with a kind of possessiveness he wasn't proud of and then, finally, cleanly. He had made mistakes. He had held on too long and too tightly and had let the holding shade into something that pressed. He had also, before all of that, been exactly the kind of friend she had said he was — the one who showed up, who remembered, who listened, who made space.

Both were true. He was all of that.

And she had been exactly what she was: kind, honest, genuinely caring, incapable of loving him the way he needed, unable to be blamed for that incapability. She had never promised. She had never deceived. She had only been herself, and her self had loved someone else.

Nobody was the villain. Nobody had cheated, lied, manipulated. The tragedy had only been the oldest and most ordinary one: two people feeling different things, at the same time, in the same place, unable to bridge it.

He thought: *loving someone deeply never means they owe you their love.*

He had known this, in theory, for three years. He was finally, standing on this Delhi street with his bag over his shoulder, knowing it in the way that truth arrives when it arrives completely: in the body, not just the mind. In the chest, where things actually live.

He exhaled.

He walked.

"Three years later, she gave him the same small wave from the first day, and he understood: some things end where they begin, only quieter."

— CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

The Space Between Waiting

There is a space that exists between waiting for something and understanding that what you were waiting for was not a thing that would arrive — that the waiting itself was the living, and you were living it the whole time without knowing.

Dhruv understood this, finally, completely, on a Thursday afternoon in October of his twenty-fifth year, sitting at a desk in the firm's small office in Pune, reviewing a set of accounts that were straightforward in their complexity, the kind of work that left part of his mind free to wander.

He was thinking about nothing in particular. He was thinking about what to have for lunch. He was thinking about a call with his mother scheduled for the evening. He was thinking about a question one of the junior CA students had asked him that week, which had been a good question, the kind that revealed someone who was actually thinking rather than just looking for an answer to copy down.

He was thinking about none of this specifically when something landed, quietly and without announcement: he was okay.

Not fine in the polite way, not managing. Okay in the actual way. The way of someone who has arrived, without noticing the journey, at a place that is genuinely theirs. His work was right for him. His colleagues were decent people. He had his own flat — small, with a window that looked at another building rather than anything scenic, but his, with his things in it, in the

particular arrangement that made sense to him. He cooked sometimes, poorly but earnestly. He had a reading habit he'd let grow back now that the exam pressure had decreased. He had called Kavya last month and she had immediately said "I told you to call me, what took so long" and they had talked for forty-five minutes about everything and nothing.

He had sent Ananya a message on her birthday in November — the 23rd, the date he still kept in his phone — and she had replied with warmth and asked how the CA was going and he had answered and she had answered and it was a brief, genuine exchange that contained within it the specific warmth of two people who have been important to each other and have reached the place where that history is simply that: history, cherished rather than painful, a thing that made them who they were and then moved aside.

He was okay.

He looked up from his accounts. The office window was ordinary, showing an ordinary afternoon. He thought about first year. He thought about the neem tree at the bus corner and the orientation hall and the fourth row and the girl with the yellow dupatta.

He thought: I was young. I was so young. I was the kind of young where you love for the first time and you don't know that love is not a transaction, that presence is not currency, that being there is not a down payment on being loved back. I didn't know any of that yet.

He thought: but I was also kind. I was genuinely, sincerely kind. I showed up. I remembered. I listened. And those things — those came from somewhere real. Those weren't wrong, even when the expectation behind them was.

He thought about the notebook she was still writing in, the blue one, the one he'd chosen because it was the color of the sky just after sunset. He hoped she was still writing in it. He hoped it was full by now, full of the things she wrote when she wanted to remember something. He hoped it was somewhere in her life in Delhi, sitting on a shelf with its spine toward the room, full of her handwriting.

He thought: that was a good gift. Whatever else was complicated about everything else, that was a good gift, chosen from knowing, and it mattered regardless of what came after.

He thought about Arjun, who was good, and who made her laugh, and who would, he hoped, go on making her laugh for a very long time. He held no resentment toward Arjun. He had let that go somewhere in the second year, when he'd met him and found him impossible to dislike. You can't sustain resentment toward someone who does nothing wrong. Eventually you have to just accept the situation and redirect the energy somewhere useful.

He had redirected it. It had taken time. But here he was.

"Loving someone deeply never means they owe you their love."

He thought about the lesson he had taken the longest to learn, the one that was the whole story, really, the core of it: that love cannot be earned through patience and sacrifice. That kindness is not a contract. That doing the most for someone does not entitle you to their heart, because hearts are not disbursed through entitlement. They move where they move, and they

don't ask for permission, and they cannot be argued or demonstrated into moving differently.

He had tried to earn her. He had given everything he had with the quiet assumption — never stated, barely conscious — that eventually the balance would tip. That enough kindness would produce the equivalent. That patience was a form of proof, that waiting was a form of deserving.

He understood now that none of that was true. Not because he had been wrong to be kind, or wrong to be patient — those things were good in themselves, regardless of outcome. But kindness and patience offered with an invisible price tag are not really kindness and patience. They are investments. And love does not pay returns on investments. It is not a market. It has no exchange rate between giving and receiving.

He had to learn this the hard way, the only way most people learn the important things: by living through the version where you don't know it yet, and arriving, slowly, on the other side.

He was on the other side. It was quieter here. It was colder than he'd imagined, but in a clean way, the cold of an early morning before the day begins, not the cold of something absent but the cold of something about to become.

His phone lit up on his desk. A message from Sameer: *Delhi trip next month. Full group reunion. You in? Kavya says if you say "I'll try" she's blocking you.*

He smiled. He typed: *I'm in.*

He put the phone back down. He went back to his accounts. Outside, the ordinary afternoon continued. In the office around him, people worked and talked and moved through their lives, each of them carrying their own weight, their own waiting, their own version of the space between what they hoped for and what arrived.

He was one of them. An ordinary person who had loved someone, who had lost something, who was figuring out what came after. Nothing spectacular. Nothing tragic in the final accounting — just human. Just real.

He thought, at some point before the afternoon ended: she was the most important person of that chapter of my life, and that chapter was exactly what it was supposed to be, and it is complete, and I am grateful for it. All of it. Even the parts that hurt. Especially those.

He thought: the most loving thing I ever did for her was the one she never knew about — the day I understood that my love was becoming something that pressed, and I tried to stop pressing. Imperfectly, yes. Too slowly, yes. But I tried. And in the trying, there was something genuinely for her rather than for me.

He thought: if that was love in its bravest form, I want to keep that capacity. I want to take it forward. Into whatever comes next — friendship, work, life, whatever shape love takes in the years that follow a first love that didn't work the way you hoped.

He thought: I'm twenty-five. There is a lot of forward.

He finished his accounts. He packed up his desk, tidily, as always. He locked the office and walked out into the Pune evening, which smelled of rain that had just finished and earth that was still remembering it.

He walked home.

He thought about what to cook, and whether to call his mother before or after dinner, and about the question the junior student had asked that morning, and about the Sameer message and the reunion and Kavya saying she'd block him, and about all the ordinary things that filled an ordinary life.

He walked through the evening, through the streets he knew by now — the shortcut through the lane with the petrol pump, the right turn at the building with the lime-green gate, the straight stretch to his building where the watchman nodded as he passed.

He walked into his flat. He turned on the light. His things were there, arranged the way he'd arranged them, comfortable in the particular way of a place that is yours.

He made tea.

He sat at his window — the one that looked at the other building, not the scenic view, just the ordinary one. He held his cup with both hands, the way she used to, the way he had always noticed, and he sat with it and was present in his own life, in the good and ordinary way, the only way that matters in the long run.

He was okay.

He was, without drama, without announcement, in the slow and steady way that real things arrive: okay.

And somewhere in Delhi, in a city that was still strange in some ways and becoming home in others, Ananya was having dinner with Arjun and

talking about something she'd found interesting during her day, and the conversation was the kind that moves easily because two people are genuinely in it, and the restaurant was warm, and outside the Delhi evening was doing its thing with the streetlights and the auto-rickshaws and the ordinary miraculous continuation of everything.

She was happy.

He knew this, with the specific certainty of someone who has paid enough attention to know, and he held it — not painlessly, but cleanly. Without bitterness. Without the wish that it were otherwise.

She was happy, and he was okay, and somewhere in that gap between the two — in the space between what he had hoped for and what had actually arrived — there was a story that was finished now. Complete, not incomplete. It had ended where it had to end, and it had taught him what it was designed to teach, and he had paid for the lesson with his twenties, the way everyone pays for their first real lessons: with the years that are old enough to know better and young enough not to.

He drank his tea.

He thought: some stories end without ever beginning. That's what the subtitle says. It's not wrong. But it's not quite all of it either.

Some stories end exactly where they were always going to end, and on the way, they make you into someone who can carry the ending. And that — the person you become by carrying it — that is not nothing. That is something. That might, in the long view, be the whole point.

He set down his cup.

He opened his notebook — the dark blue one, almost full now, three years of evenings in its pages — and he wrote the last thing he would write about this, the last entry, the final sentence of a chapter that was ready to be closed:

I loved her. She didn't love me that way. Neither of us was wrong. I'm okay. That's the whole story, and it's enough.

He closed the notebook. He didn't open it again that night.

Outside, the evening continued in all its ordinary persistence. The city breathed. The world held its shape. Time moved forward, as it does, indifferent and reliable, carrying everything with it — the pain, the memory, the love that didn't land where it aimed, and the person who survived it and is sitting, right now, quietly, in a flat with a window that looks at another building, making peace with all of it.

Making peace.

Quietly.

One evening at a time.

"He loved her the way the rain loves the ground — completely, without asking to be needed, changing things whether it was wanted or not. The ground moved on. The rain became something else. Both were real. Both were right."

"Loving someone deeply never means they owe you their love. And understanding that — truly, in the bones — is the last and bravest thing a heart can learn."

— CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO · THE END

FIN

The Space Between Waiting

"Some stories end without ever beginning."

Written by **Yash**